

Tuesday, September 15, 2026

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Rising inflation sparks buzz of early rate hike ▶ P1



Tata, Adani, RIL fire up EV charging web ▶ P1

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RC/REP/HARERA/GGM/1085/817/2026/57 DT. 26.08.2026
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Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

Why counterfeit drugs are getting harder to detect

BY JESSICA JANI

Two major cases of counterfeit life-saving drugs uncovered in the past two weeks have raised concern among consumers. Executives say this is a growing challenge, with fake drugs becoming harder to detect. *Mint* explains the problem, its impact, and the regulatory response.



MINT

1 Why is counterfeit drugs in the news now?

On 13 Sept, a team of Bengaluru police and the drugs control department uncovered a large racket suspected of supplying fake cancer drugs, ICU injections and other life-saving medicines to over 90 hospitals and clinics at up to 50% off. A week earlier, reports said the drug regulator had flagged a batch of rabies vaccine Abhayrab as substandard and potentially spurious after it failed a potency test. The batch had been seized during a Delhi raid in April. Abhayrab manufacturer Indian Immunologicals Ltd, which has a 40% share of India's rabies vaccine market, said it had not made the flagged vials.

ISTOCKPHOTO



2 How serious is the problem?

Counterfeit drugs are an enduring problem in India. Reports indicate fake medicines account for a sizable portion of the healthcare market. Many cases involve over-the-counter and oral drugs, as well as nutraceuticals and supplements, but authorities are increasingly finding fake life-saving medicines such as cancer drugs and vaccines. About 15-20% of products in India's healthcare market are believed to be fake, according to a 2025 report by Crisil and the Authentication Solution Providers' Association. That compares with 0.2% in the US and Europe, a 2025 report in the Indian Journal of Pharmacy Practice said.

3 How are consumers affected?

Spurious drugs—often sold via direct retail or unverified online stores—can be life-threatening by causing treatment failure, poisoning, or antimicrobial resistance. The Aspa-Crisil 2025 report found 33% of consumers encountered fake healthcare products in the past year, with perceived market penetration rising from 20% in 2018 to 28% in 2025.

4 What do experts say?

Experts said counterfeiters are becoming harder to detect, copying QR codes and holograms and procuring packaging material from original suppliers. Interstate networks and complex supply chains make these operations harder to trace. The problem is increasingly extending to cancer drugs and vaccines, Sudarshan Jain, secretary general of the Indian Pharmaceutical Alliance, told *Moneycontrol* after the Abhayrab samples were flagged. He called for stronger laws and fast-track courts to deal with counterfeit medicine cases.

5 What are regulators doing?

In June, the health ministry expanded the QR code-based track-and-trace framework to all vaccines, antimicrobials, anti-cancer drugs and narcotic and psychotropic drugs covered under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act, 1985. Drugmakers have until July 2027 to add the QR code to packaging. The system previously covered India's top 300 pharma brands. The expansion is intended to widen traceability and strengthen safeguards against counterfeit and substandard medicines.

QUICK EDIT

Inflation build-up

Inflationary pressures have begun to build up. Government data shows consumer inflation climbed to 4.8% in August, year-on-year. This marked the third-straight month that this gauge, which RBI tracks for framing monetary policy, has topped the central bank's 4% target. Separate government data, also released on Monday, showed wholesale inflation inched up to 9.9% in August compared with 9.8% in July. Both the readings are in line with economists' expectations as deficient rainfall seems to have hurt farm output and driven up food prices. These pressures could intensify in the months ahead. More worryingly, Brent crude oil prices hit \$107 a barrel amid a flare-up in the West Asia conflict. This could send fuel prices up and stoke broader inflationary pressures. Notably, India's economy has been growing robustly despite the effects of tariffs and global supply disruptions. This grants RBI space to keep its gaze on inflation, especially as the US Federal Reserve looks set to tighten policy this week, which could pressure the rupee down if a squeezed rate spread over US assets results in capital outflows. All considered, it may be best if RBI tightens monetary conditions in India.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

AI creates opportunity, but also requires safeguards through the right kind of governance approach... We have to work for a connectivity that is intelligent, use of AI that is responsible, innovation is to be encouraged, and every citizen is to be empowered by technology.

ANIL KUMAR LAHOTI
CHAIRMAN, TRAI

Lahoti was speaking at an event in New Delhi.



INSIDE

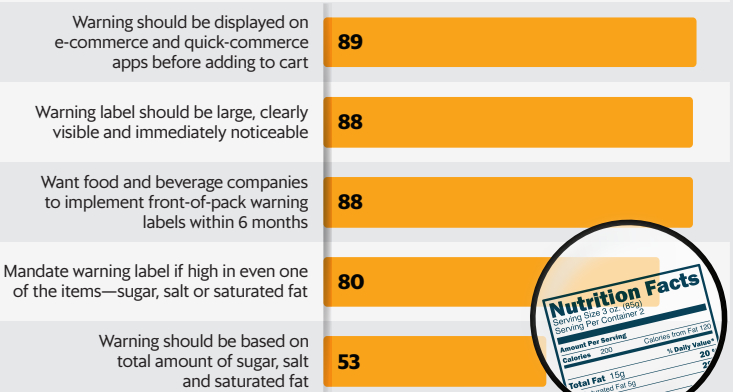
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mint | DATA BITES

HOW DO CONSUMERS WANT FOOD WARNINGS TO WORK?

FSSAI has proposed red warnings for packaged foods high in sugar, salt or fat. More than eight in 10 consumers want these warnings and want them implemented within six months.

Share of respondents who want the following (in %)



The survey covered over 108,000 people across 328 districts in India.

Data: Rupanjal Chauhan
Graphic: Deepak Mishra

Source: LocalCircles

COLUMNS



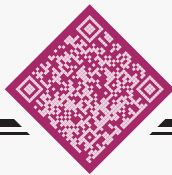
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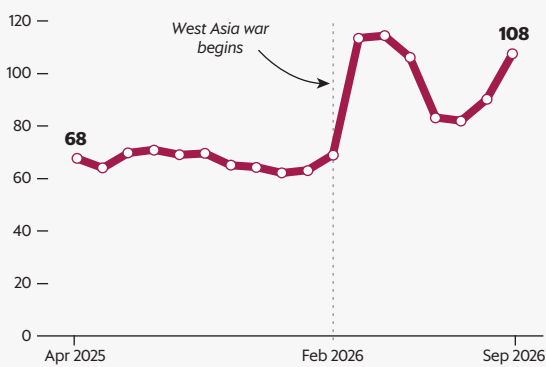
INDIA'S ENERGY PLAN AMID THE IRAN WAR

BY HOWINDIALIVES.COM

The end of August marked six months since the attack on Iran by the US and Israel. Since then, it's been a rollercoaster ride for global crude oil prices. Prices surged to above \$110 per barrel between March and May, but saw a sharp slide as a fragile ceasefire took hold. However, hostilities between the two sides have flared up again, and crude oil is back above the \$100 a barrel mark. High oil prices, coupled with serious disruptions to oil flows through West Asia, were never good news for the Indian economy, which remains heavily dependent on crude imports. While it has coped with the disruption so far, the economy has suffered on various fronts.

The average price of the Indian crude basket has again crossed \$100 a barrel

Average price of Indian crude oil basket (in \$ per barrel)



Data for September 2026 is until 11 September.

Source: Petroleum planning & analysis cell



PRICE STRAIN

IN NORMAL times, the Indian crude basket comprises Brent crude oil (the global benchmark) and the lesser-known Dubai-Oman benchmark in roughly a 70:30 split. As the crisis wore on, and Iran's strikes on oil facilities in neighbouring countries such as Oman gathered pace, supplies to India were hit as well. India had to look elsewhere for crude supplies, changing this ratio to 78:22 in September so far. Beyond this mix, the cost of the Indian crude basket reflects broader trends in the oil market. It was \$69 per barrel in February. With the resumption of hostilities, it has crossed \$100 again this month.

Crude is not the only problem for India. A parallel surge in gold prices driven by global market uncertainty has hit the trade deficit (exports minus imports) on two fronts. As the import bill of both items increased, the trade deficit rose to \$86.6 billion in April-June 2026, against \$68.7 billion in April-June 2025.

COUNTRY MOVEMENTS

AS THE conflict unfolded, India's primary challenge was navigating disrupted trade routes and sourcing alternatives.

While West Asia historically supplied the bulk of India's crude, Russia's share has expanded significantly.

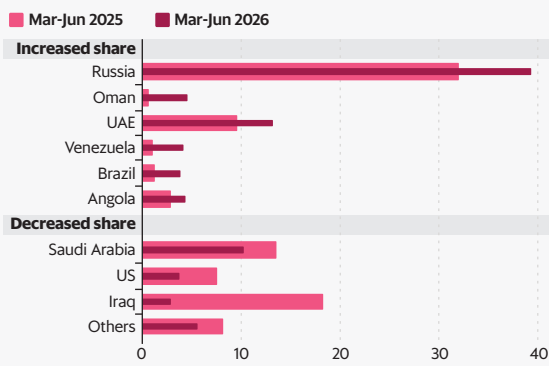
Between March and June 2026, the latest period for which detailed trade data is available, Russia accounted for 39% of India's crude imports, up from 32% in the year-ago period.

Supplies from Saudi Arabia were disrupted as the key shipping route from the Gulf, the Strait of Hormuz, was blockaded.

Further, the share of Iraq, a key supplier to India, declined sharply from 18% to 3%. Meanwhile, several countries' share in India's crude import basket increased, notably Iran and Venezuela, both of which involved a tacit nod from the US for India to increase crude purchases.

India bought more oil from Russia since the US-Iran war, while Iraq's share fell sharply

Country-wise volume share in India's crude oil imports (in %)



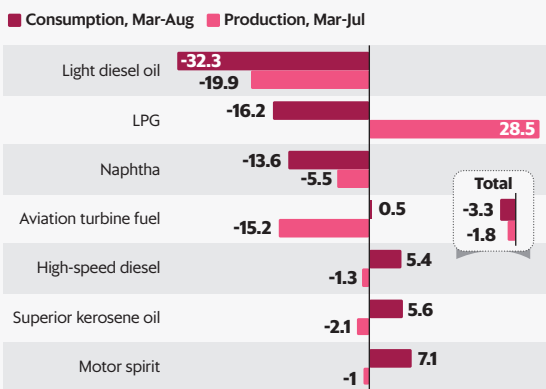
Countries are arranged in respective sets in descending order of Mar-Jun 2026 share.

Source: Commerce ministry



Both consumption and output of some petroleum products have fallen since March

Change between 2025 and 2026 (in %)



Source: Petroleum planning & analysis cell



DEMAND DESTRUCTION

THE SUPPLY disruptions caused by the closure of the Strait of Hormuz have led to predictions that crude oil prices could rise well beyond \$200 per barrel. It was expected to cause what economists call 'demand destruction' — sharp declines in demand for fuel because consumers are unable, beyond a point, to pay.

However, analysts were surprised at the extent to which demand fell. In a July report, JP Morgan analysts said the pullback in fuel consumption "appeared] to have been substantially larger than first thought." In India too, consumption fell sharply, with government data showing that demand fell at a faster pace than the decline in petroleum product supplies.

Overall production of petroleum products fell by 2% in the four months from March to July 2026 compared to the corresponding period last year. In contrast, the consumption of petroleum products fell about 3.3%. The case of LPG is fascinating — production increased 29% even as consumption fell 16%.

HOUSEHOLD MATTERS

FUEL PRICE hikes are inherently politically sensitive—even more so as the US-Iran conflict and West Asian supply disruptions coincided with upcoming assembly elections in key states like West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Assam, and Kerala.

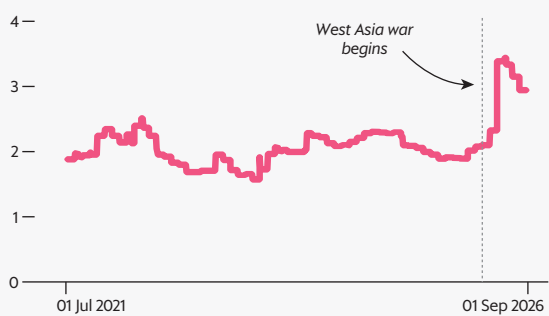
Facing acute shortages of LPG, the primary household cooking fuel, the government shifted the supply burden onto commercial users to protect domestic consumers.

Indian Oil Corporation (IOC) provides data on prices of 14.2 kg LPG cylinders (mainly for home use) and 19 kg cylinders (for use in hotels and restaurants). In general, the cylinder intended for commercial use is priced higher.

Since 2021, the average commercial-to-domestic price ratio has ranged from 1.5 to 2.5, meaning the 19 kg cylinder costs 1.5-2.5 times the 14.2 kg one. Over the past six months, however, this ratio spiked as high 3.44 before easing to 2.95 at present.

The price markup in commercial LPG over household LPG rose sharply

Average price of commercial LPG in multiples* of domestic LPG across metros (in times)



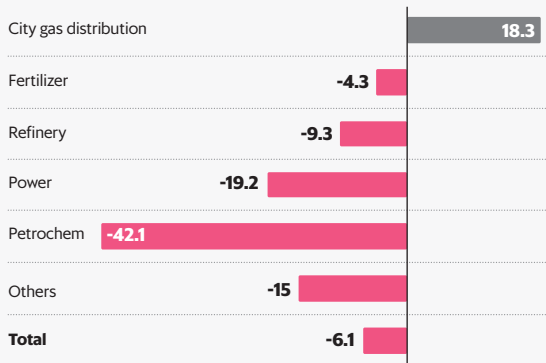
*Ratio of the average price of a 19 kg cylinder (used mainly in commercial establishments) to the price of a 14.2 kg cylinder (used by households) across the four metros.

Source: Indian Oil Corporation



Offtake of natural gas has dropped across sectors, other than city gas distribution

Year-on-year change in consumption of natural gas (in %), Mar-Jul 2026



Source: Petroleum planning & analysis cell



CHAIN REACTION

BEYOND CRUDE, natural gas suffered severe supply shocks after strikes on Qatar's key processing facilities crippled global output. For India, which imports about half its natural gas, this was a major challenge. Again, demand had to adjust, but where would the burden of adjustment fall? The biggest consumers of natural gas in India are fertilizer plants, followed by city gas distribution networks and power plants. For the five months from March to July, five of the six categories of consumers saw consumption fall. The exception was city gas networks, which saw consumption rise 18%. To compensate, consumption by the fertiliser sector dropped 4% and the power sector 19%. In other words, the government went to great lengths to protect supplies of cooking fuel to consumers, while trying to hold prices stable. Other stakeholders paid for it, absorbing rising prices of a key input, which also had an effect on prices down the line.

www.howindialives.com is a database and search engine for public data.

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Inside a monumental crisis for artificial intelligence ▶ P10



Coforge hires Egon Zehnder after twin exits at top level ▶ P6

SENSEX **74,781.76** ↕ 0.00

NIFTY **23,398.1** ↕ 0.00

DOLLAR **₹95.55** ↕ ₹0.00

EURO **₹110.81** ↕ ₹0.00

OIL **\$105.44** ↑ \$1.97

POUND **₹128.88** ↑ ₹0.19

Rising inflation sparks buzz of early rate hike

Retail inflation hits 20-month high of 4.82%; wholesale inflation nears double digits

Subhash Narayan & Banikankar Pattanayak

NEW DELHI

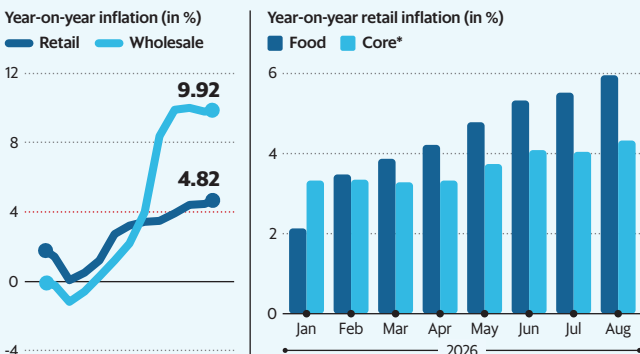
India's economy, which grew a stronger-than-expected 7.8% in the June quarter, is facing fresh headwinds as food and fuel prices continue to surge while price pressures start trickling into the broader economy. Both retail and wholesale inflation accelerated in August, the two datasets released on Monday showed, with the broader rise fanning expectations of a rate hike sooner than later.

Consumer price inflation rose to a 20-month high of 4.82% in August from 4.45% in July, breaching the Reserve Bank of India's 4% midpoint target for the third consecutive month. Wholesale price inflation, meanwhile, inched closer to the double-digit mark, rising to 9.92% from 9.78%, as geopolitical tensions pushed up energy costs and food prices stayed firm.

The simultaneous rise in the two inflation gauges points to intensifying price pressures across the economy. The risks are particularly pronounced as the conflict in West Asia keeps crude oil prices elevated and an El Niño-influenced, below-par monsoon threatens the sum-

RISING TIDE

The simultaneous rise in the retail and wholesale inflation points to intensifying price pressures across the Indian economy.



Source: Statistics ministry, CMIE

HOT PICKS

- PRESSURES** rise as war fuels oil prices, food prices stay high
- CPI-WPI** gap shows some price pain yet to be passed on
- RISING** core inflation points to broader price pressures

SATISH KUMAR/MINT

mer crop that could put further pressure on food prices.

At its last meeting on 3-5 August, RBI's monetary policy committee retained the repo rate at 5.25% and maintained a neutral stance. The central bank has projected India's FY27 growth at 6.7% and the average headline inflation at 5%.

Food inflation in the consumer

price index (CPI) rose to 5.95% in August from 5.52% in July, while wholesale food inflation (WPI) crossed 7%, up from 6.6% in the previous month. Under the wholesale index, inflation in crude petroleum and natural gas surged to 34.41% from 26.99%, pushing up fuel and power inflation to 22.93% from 20.05%.

"The uptick was broad-based, driven by 10 of the 12 divisions, (with) food and beverages, housing, water, electricity, gas and other fuels, and information and communications divisions accounting for a bulk of the 37-basis-point uptick" in headline retail inflation in August, said Aditi Nayar, chief economist, and head-research and outreach at Icria Ltd.

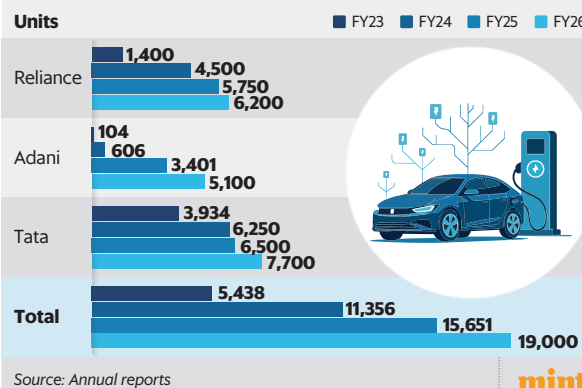
The pressure could intensify in the coming months. Nayar expects food and beverage inflation to cross 7% by October and headline retail inflation to breach 5% in September, before rising to around 6% in October-November.

Some experts see the inflation chart less spiky. "Going forward, we expect headline inflation to stay range-bound near 4.5-5.0%, with food as the key swing factor amid uneven monsoon and El Niño-related uncertainty," said Rajeev Sharan, head of research, Brickwork Ratings. "The main risk is that high wholesale food and input costs eventually push up retail prices, alongside any rise in crude oil or fresh volatility in vegetable prices."

The prolonged West Asia conflict has emerged as a key risk to India's inflation outlook. Brent crude oil prices have surged

Power drive

Conglomerates' EV charging points have grown 21% from FY25.



Source: Annual reports

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

Tata, Adani, RIL fire up EV charging web

Ayaan Kartik
ayaan.kartik@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

India's largest conglomerates, Tata, Adani and Reliance, have rapidly expanded their electric vehicle (EV) charging networks, with their combined installed charging points more than tripling to 19,000 over the past three years, as they look to challenge public sector undertakings (PSUs), who continue to dominate the ecosystem.

Data reviewed by *Mint* from annual reports of the companies and their executives shows these conglomerates have accelerated the push over the last few years: Tata Group's Tata Power leads with 7,700 charging points, followed by the Reliance Group's 6,200

and the Adani Group's 5,100 charging points by end FY26.

The number of EV charging points installed by them has grown 21% from FY25, when the total was 15,651 and by 67% from FY24, when it was 11,356. From 5,438 in FY23, the network has grown 280%.

Built mainly for electric passenger vehicles, buses and trucks, these charging points are set up at public, semi-public and private charging stations that also cover malls, hotels, hospitals, etc.

Latest data on the total number of public and private charging points is not readily available, with the heavy industries ministry estimating the number of public charging stations at about 29,151 at the

TURN TO PAGE 9

DON'T MISS



Macquarie Asset buys stake in Maple Infrastructure Trust

Macquarie Asset Management (MAM) has acquired a stake in Maple Infrastructure Trust, which owns and operates toll roads across India, from global investment group La Caisse, the companies said in a statement on Monday.

▶ P3

Victura picks Rothschild to help with \$300-400 million IPO

Faridabad-based Victura Group, which makes components for the auto sector, has picked Rothschild as an advisor to oversee its public listing process that could raise as much as \$300-400 million, two people familiar with the matter said.

▶ P4

DRI seizes Pakistan-origin dry dates routed through UAE

The Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) has seized over 362 tonnes of dry dates originating in Pakistan after uncovering an alleged attempt to circumvent India's ban on imports from Pakistan by routing the consignment through the UAE.

▶ P9

InsuranceDekho co-founders express intent to step down

InsuranceDekho co-founders Ankit Agrawal and Ish Babbar have expressed their intent to step down from the IPO-bound company over strategic differences with some members of the board, people familiar with the matter said.

▶ P3



Orbicular's scientists are focused on establishing a one-stop shop to ensure seamless delivery of highly complex products. BLOOMBERG

PE majors circle Orbicular, value pegged at \$1.5 bn

Priyamvada C & Sneha Shah
MUMBAI

Orbicular Pharmaceutical Technologies has attracted early interest from private equity firms including Warburg Pincus and CVC Capital Partners, as the specialty pharmaceutical firm explores a stake sale in a deal that will likely value the company at up to \$1.5 billion, three people familiar with the matter said.

"The company has mandated Jefferies as the advisor and existing investor Tata Capital Healthcare Fund is likely to explore a part or full exit as a part of the transaction," one of the people cited above said on the condition of anonymity.

"The exact quantum of the stake sale and valuation may evolve depending on the incoming investor," the second person said.

"While the deal is in its early days, CVC and Warburg are spending some time on the asset. The deal will officially be launched over the next quarter, with other private equity firms and strategics also expected to evaluate the company for a potential investment at a valuation of between \$1 billion and \$1.5 billion," said

TURN TO PAGE 6

VCs put food startups under lens as regulator widens crackdown

Nabodita Ganguly
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NEW DELHI

As India's food regulator steps up scrutiny, investors are changing how they assess food and health-focused consumer startups, turning product claims, ingredient quality and supply-chain traceability into potential deal-breakers.

Investors are going beyond licences and certifications to examine whether claims on packaging can be substantiated, whether ingredients match those claims and whether manufacturers can be traced and audited. For some, weak evidence is now enough to walk away from a deal.

The shift comes as the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has intensified enforcement across food and health-focused companies. Risk-based inspections rose from 11,904 in FY23 to 26,267 in FY25, according to a



FSSAI sent notices to 150 firms over misleading ads. BLOOMBERG

government release in March 2026. In August, FSSAI issued notices to more than 150 companies over misleading advertisements, false claims and labelling non-compliance, according to a post by the food regulator on social media.

For some investors, inadequate substantiation is no longer a diligence issue to be resolved after an investment decision. It can kill the deal.

"I'll not take the name of the brand, but I recently came

across a snacking brand that claimed 'zero percent fat' or 'zero palm oil' on the front of the pack. However, on the back of the pack, it listed hydrogenated vegetable oil... So, we said no to that deal," said Ankita Balotia, principal at VC firm Fireside Ventures.

"We have become very clear that it is not only about being label-proof; contract manufacturers and traceability across the supply chain also need to meet a much higher standard than before. And this needs to be maintained on a continuing basis because companies will keep launching more and newer products," said Balotia.

Fireside has conducted in-house training to help its team assess product claims, validate them and determine what follow-up questions to ask.

In another example, Balotia said, "I was meeting a protein company today whose key

TURN TO PAGE 6

FDA's Mundhe prods NPPA for cheaper medical items

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NEW DELHI

Some hospital surgical consumables and medical devices are being sold at markups as high as 2,841% over their trade procurement price in certain cases, according to a Maharashtra government survey—prompting the state's food and drug regulator, Tukaram Mundhe, to seek a national review of device pricing rules.

Mundhe has written to the Department of Pharmaceuticals and the National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA), the country's drug pricing regulator, seeking a review of the survey's findings and appropriate action—including capping trade margins or bringing essential device categories under structured price monitoring.

Mundhe's foray into hospital pricing follows an aggressive run at Mumbai's food sector, when his inspections led to the

Device dossier

Maharashtra FDA called for capping trade margins or bringing essential categories under price monitoring.

Item	Procurement price (in ₹)	Patient MRP (in ₹)
IV infusion sets	11.05	325
10ml syringe	6.75	57
Nebulizer kit	40	715
IV cannula line	22.50	424
Balloon catheter	29.41	310
Hepa filter	50.68	473

Source: Maharashtra FDA

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

temporary shutdown of several well-known eateries over hygiene violations. The move made him one of the state's most closely watched regulators—and signals that hospitals and device makers should expect similar scrutiny.

"Our survey has revealed an extraordinary disparity between the trade procurement price and the printed

maximum retail prices (MRP) of medical devices used in inpatient care, reaching as high as 2,841% in some cases, including IV sets, syringes, nebulizers and oxygen mask products," Mundhe said in an interview. These products remain outside the direct ceiling-price mechanism under

TURN TO PAGE 6

India's space boom is creating a new business for lawyers

Krishna Yadav & Yash Tiwari
NEW DELHI/MUMBAI

India's space industry is becoming a bigger business for lawyers as private companies, investors and foreign players move deeper into a sector where raising capital or doing business can bring questions around national security, technology transfers, exports and regulation.

The country's space ecosystem has expanded rapidly, with registered space startups rising from one in 2014 to around 440 in 2026, per government data of 14 August.

The space economy, valued at \$9 billion in August, is seen at \$40-45 billion in a decade. The result is a growing

range of legal work: from foreign investment and regulatory nods to tech transfers, fundraising, joint ventures and commercial contracts.

"We have seen a steady rise in legal mandates in the space sector. This has been driven by a combination of regulatory reforms and increased private and foreign investment," said Ankita Kumar, partner at Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas, who advises clients on defence-related matters spanning structuring, procurement regulation, technology transfer and foreign collaboration.

Businesses that were once vendors to the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) are now building independent ventures, driving demand for



India's space economy was valued at \$9 billion as of August, with projections to reach \$40-45 billion over the next decade. PTI

legal advice, said Kumar.

Law firms are advising space-tech startups, unicorns, investors and established aerospace firms on funding, foreign investment, Indian

National Space Promotion and Authorisation Centre (IN-SPACE) approvals, technology transfers, M&A, commercial contracts, intellectual property and export controls.

Foreign firms are also exploring Indian subsidiaries and joint ventures following the liberalization of foreign direct investment (FDI) rules.

"We are seeing early interest from foreign entities exploring an Indian subsidiary or JV route to access the liberalized FDI caps, though listed aerospace/defence primes remain a smaller share of our current mandates than the startup and investor side," said Siddharth Mody, partner, JSA Advocates & Solicitors specializing in M&As, private equity (PE) and venture capital (VC).

JSA recently advised an Indian space-tech firm on a pre-Series B funding round involving the investment arm of a large diversified financial-

services group. The mandate included checks on the firm's IN-SPACE authorization status, Isro technology-transfer arrangements and exposure to dual-use export controls.

"The common thread across these mandates is that investors are no longer treating space/deep-tech as a niche allocation as it now sits alongside their mainstream technology and financial-services deal flow but with an added regulatory diligence layer," Mody said.

Khaitan & Co. is also seeing rising demand from investors entering the sector. Sanchit Agarwal, a partner in its corporate and commercial practice,

TURN TO PAGE 6



MINT SHORTS

India, Canada begin next round of talks on proposed trade pact

New Delhi: India and Canada on Monday started the fourth round of negotiations for the proposed Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (Cepa) here, as the two sides look to conclude the talks this year, an official said. The issues that would figure in the five-day (14–18 September) talks include trade in goods, services, rules of origin, and technical trade barriers, among others.

PTI

Civic bodies to raise ₹10,000 cr from GMB issues till FY30



ISTOCKPHOTO

Mumbai: Civic bodies in India may raise ₹10,000 crore through green municipal bonds (GMBs) over the next 30 months, a report said on Monday. Pegging the required urban infrastructure investments at over ₹56 trillion during FY27–30, domestic rating agency Ica said up to ₹3 trillion of this amount will be raised from commercial debt financing route.

PTI

India approves export of power to Nepal after deadly flood

New Delhi: India has approved export of power to Nepal for 18 hours a day until 31 December after a devastating flood in the Himalayan nation last month wiped out about a tenth of its generation capacity, neighbour India's power ministry said on Monday. The deluge, triggered by the collapse of a glacier, has killed nearly 1,400 people in Nepal and Tibet, and swept away more than 12 hydropower plants in Nepal.

REUTERS

India gains wider EU steel access, but carbon levy stays



New Delhi: India will be able to export up to 1.64 million tonnes (mt) of steel a year to the European Union under a free trade agreement, but exporters will still face carbon-related costs, as per legal text of the pact. The agreement provides India with an additional preferential quota of 694,853 tonnes of steel, on top of an existing 946,616-tonne WTO quota. The combined quota is equivalent to about 68.4% of India's 2.4mt of steel exports to the EU in 2025.

REUTERS

Average sugar retail price rules below ₹60 per kilo for 4th day

New Delhi: The average all-India retail price of sugar remained below ₹60 per kg for the fourth straight day on Monday following a series of government measures, even as festive demand put upward pressure on prices in some regions. On Monday, the average retail sugar price stood at ₹59.57 per kg, marginally up from ₹58.99 per kg the previous day. Sugar prices dropped below the ₹60 per kg level on Friday and eased further in the last three days, as per consumer affairs ministry data.

PTI

India, China discuss deepening energy cooperation

Beijing: India and China discussed deepening energy cooperation as a senior Chinese oil corporation executive met petroleum and natural gas minister Hardeep Singh Puri in New Delhi on Monday. China National Petroleum Corporation chairman Dai Houliang met with Puri in New Delhi and exchanged views on deepening energy cooperation, official media reported.

REUTERS

India's pump storage project pipeline needs ₹7.36 trillion

Centre wants to scale storage to support its rapidly expanding renewable power capacity

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NEW DELHI

India's pipeline to build 122.77 gigawatts (GW) of pumped storage capacity through 87 projects may require an investment of ₹7.36 trillion, according to industry experts, as the government seeks to add large-scale storage to support its rapidly expanding renewable power capacity.

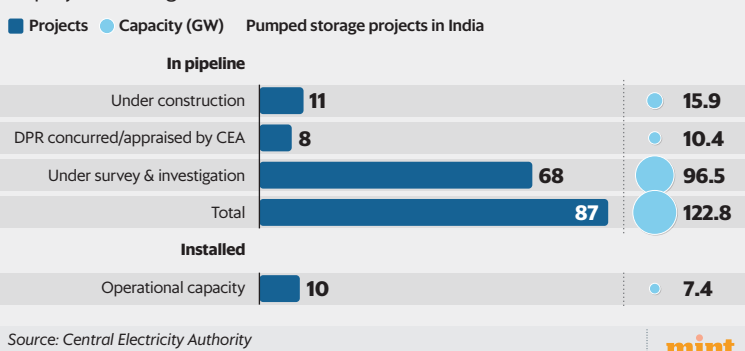
The push is significant as India seeks to meet its 2030 target of 500GW of non-fossil power capacity while managing the variability of solar and wind generation. Pumped storage plants can absorb surplus renewable power during off-peak hours and release it when demand rises, providing longer-duration storage and helping maintain grid stability as the share of variable renewable energy increases.

According to data from the Central Electricity Authority (CEA), the country's apex power-sector planning body, 15.87GW of pumped storage projects are under construction as of August 2026, while another 10.4GW have received CEA clearance. Survey and investigation are underway for a further 96.5GW of potential capacity. CEA has already come up with a road map to install 100GW of PSP capacity by 2035–36.

The need for storage has become more pressing as India has been unable

Project pipeline

India is looking to build 122.77GW of pumped storage capacity through 87 projects, calling for an investment of ₹7.36 trillion.



SATISH KUMAR/MINT

to fully leverage its intermittent solar and wind resources. Inadequate storage can threaten grid stability when generation falls because of cloud cover, rain or lower wind speeds, while sudden changes in demand can also affect grid frequency, which needs to remain between 49.90 and 50.05 hertz (Hz).

In its road map for pumped storage capacity, the CEA has estimated an average cost of ₹6 crore per megawatt, putting the cost of developing 122.77GW at about ₹7.36 trillion, according to experts. India currently has 7.42GW of pumped storage capacity, including the 1,000MW Tehri project commissioned in 2025. The CEA estimates the

country has potential for 345.38GW of pumped storage projects.

The investment push comes against the backdrop of 43GW of solar power capacity yet to find buyers, with power distribution companies making distressed sales of green power on exchanges at prices significantly below their procurement costs.

Pumped storage projects have a higher upfront cost than battery energy storage systems, at about ₹6 crore per MW compared with around ₹2 crore per MW for BESS, and can take up to five years to build.

But PSPs have a lifecycle of around 100 years, about 10 times that of BESS. They are also generally designed for

₹6 cr
The average cost per megawatt for pumped storage

West Asia war sends Brent to \$110 a barrel

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NEW DELHI

Crude prices extended their rally on Monday as talks between Iran and other West Asian countries on Strait of Hormuz operations were postponed, while Houthis attacks on a Saudi airbase added to concerns about further conflict in the Red Sea region.

The November contract of Brent on the Intercontinental Exchange was at \$109 a barrel at around 6.40 pm, up 4.20% from previous close. The October contract of West Texas Intermediate rose 4.42% to \$104.47 a barrel on the New York Mercantile Exchange.

Al Jazeera reported that Houthis had taken control of Yemen's Red Sea coastline, consolidating their hold over the Bab al-Mandeb Strait, a key chokepoint for maritime traffic in the region. The waterway

handles about 12% of global trade, including 11% of maritime oil trade. The Houthis said they launched a large-scale ballistic missile and drone attack on Saudi Arabia's King Khalid Air Base in Khams Mushait, according to Al Jazeera. Last week, the militia captured the Red Sea city of Mocha, widening its hold over the strategic Bab al-Mandeb Strait. Separately, negotiations in Oman between Iran and

Gulf Arab states were postponed at the request of some regional countries, according to Iranian media. The postponement followed an attack on an Iranian commercial cargo vessel that killed one person in the Strait of Hormuz. Escalating West Asia hostilities are raising the risk of supply disruptions, threatening to push up India's crude import bill while fuelling inflationary and fiscal pressures.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Western Australia steps up India push

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NEW DELHI

Western Australia is stepping up efforts to deepen ties with India, with critical minerals, energy transition and direct air links high on the agenda as a trade and investment mission led by Premier Roger Cook visits the country this week.

The mission will travel to India and Vietnam from 17–25 September, seeking to expand opportunities for Western Australian businesses and institutions, according to a statement from the Western Australian government on Monday.

The delegation will meet government, business, industry and education stakeholders in Mumbai and Delhi, as well as in Vietnam. Its agenda includes energy transition, primary industries and international education.

In India, the delegation will meet major airlines, with securing a future direct connection between Perth and India a priority. Cook will also attend the opening of the University of Western Australia's



Critical minerals, energy transition and direct air links are high on Western Australia Premier Roger Cook's India visit agenda. AFP

Mumbai campus, making it the first Australian Group of Eight university to establish a campus in India. India was Western Australia's largest international student market last year, with more than 15,000 enrolments.

The mission is also aimed at positioning Western Australia as a long-term energy-transition partner, strengthening aviation and tourism links, promoting primary industries

and expanding skills and training pathways.

The visit comes as Western Australia, a leading global supplier of critical minerals including lithium, rare earths, nickel and cobalt, seeks to deepen its economic ties with India. India is already working with Australia to secure supplies of these minerals.

Indian companies, including state-owned firms, are also looking to acquire overseas

assets. National Mineral Development Corp. Ltd (NMDC) is already present in Western Australia through its subsidiary Legacy Iron Ore Ltd, which has investments in a gold mine in Mount Celia.

The mission comes days after Prime Minister Narendra Modi, while chairing the Brics summit, spoke against the weaponization of critical minerals and technologies. "The weaponization of technology and critical minerals can hinder our shared progress. Therefore, we have emphasised inclusivity in the adoption of technology," he had said at a Brics session.

China's curbs on rare-earth exports imposed last April, although later eased, disrupted global supply chains, including for India's automobile industry. Critical minerals are used across sectors including energy transition, communications, defence and pharmaceuticals.

India's total trade with Australia stood at \$21.09 billion in 2025–26, with Indian imports from Australia at \$13.81 billion, according to data from the commerce ministry.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

CGHS maps domestic manufacturing capacity for 153 critical drugs

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NEW DELHI

The health ministry is mapping the domestic manufacturing capacity of 153 specialized medicines and identifying potential suppliers in a bid to boost the availability of critical drugs to beneficiaries of the Central Government Health Scheme (CGHS), according to two government officials and a document reviewed by Mint.

The government currently procures these specialized drugs on a case-by-case basis after individual prescriptions

are submitted. This often results in prolonged wait times and personal expenses for patients.

CGHS has directed pharmaceutical manufacturers and authorized importers to submit regulatory and production filings for these oncology, diabetes, spinal muscular atrophy therapy and bi-specific antibody drugs within 15 days. Firms must disclose whether they are primary producers, importers, loan licensees or third-party manufacturers and provide approvals from the Central Drugs Standard Control Organization.

"This will help CGHS transi-



BLOOMBERG

The Centre procures these specialized drugs on a case-by-case basis when individual prescriptions are submitted.

tion towards centralized bulk procurement to ensure uninterrupted clinical access, with the data to help India's health

and family welfare ministry to ensure domestic supply resilience and track patent expiries for the availability of generic

drugs," an official familiar with the matter said, requesting anonymity.

Queries sent to the health ministry spokesperson remained unanswered till press time.

CGHS serves 4.2 million central government employees and pensioners and their dependent family members.

According to Dr Narendra Kumar Jolly, a senior consultant at Jolly Healthcare, a Jaipur-based pharma and life sciences company, the move by CGHS is a significant step towards strengthening India's healthcare supply chain. "Ensuring timely access to

specialized therapies, particularly in oncology, rare diseases and chronic conditions, requires greater visibility of domestic manufacturing capabilities and a coordinated ecosystem involving manufacturers, regulators and healthcare providers," he said. "Building such robust medicine availability systems will be crucial to ensuring that patients receive the right therapy at the right time, without unnecessary financial or logistical barriers."

The request for information from manufacturers and authorized importers was issued by the Medical Store Depot of the CGHS in a memo

dated 7 September. The schedule covers 153 high-value formulations across oncology, immunology and metabolic disorders.

Key oncology agents include abemaciclib tablets in 50mg, 100mg, 150mg and 200mg strengths for treatment of breast cancer, alongside trastuzumab deruxtecan (Enhertu) 100mg injection and ado-trastuzumab emtansine. Other targeted cancer therapies listed include alectinib, alpelisib, daratumumab, durvalumab, dostarlimab and venetoclax.

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Macquarie has invested about \$450 million, including a \$150 million of additional equity earmarked for Maple's future acquisitions. MINT

Macquarie Asset acquires stake in Maple Infra Trust

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MUMBAI

Macquarie Asset Management (MAM) has acquired a stake in Maple Infrastructure Trust, which owns and operates toll roads across India, from global investment group La Caisse, the companies said in a statement on Monday.

Macquarie has invested about \$450 million, including a \$150 million of additional equity earmarked for Maple's future acquisitions, through its fourth Asia-Pacific Infrastructure Fund, while La Caisse has infused about \$150 million to support its growth ambitions. The companies did not disclose the exact shareholding and valuation of the deal.

Following the transaction on 11 September, MAM and La Caisse will jointly own controlling stakes in the Infrastructure Investment Trust's investment manager and project manager.

This comes against the backdrop of India emerging as one of the world's largest and most diverse transport networks, with a road network extending around six million kilometres. As the country's middle class expands, rising vehicle ownership and growing mobility needs are driving increased demand for high-quality transport infrastructure, including toll roads and electrification solutions.

The partnership combines MAM's infrastructure investment and active asset management experience in India with La Caisse's experience in developing, scaling, and managing infrastructure platforms globally, the statement said.

"India remains a key market for Macquarie, and Maple reflects our conviction in the

country's long-term infrastructure opportunity," said Verena Lim, co-head of Asia-Pacific Infrastructure for Macquarie Asset Management and Asia chief executive for Macquarie Group.

"Drawing on our experienced local team and long-standing presence in the market and sector, we look forward to partnering with La Caisse to support Maple's next phase of growth, building on the platform's strong foundations through our operational expertise and active asset management approach."

Established in 2021 and sponsored by Canada's La Caisse, Maple owns and operates seven toll roads across six states in eastern, northern and southern India through long-term concession frameworks. The road network has an aggregate length of about 3,328 lane kilometres.

La Caisse has infused about \$150 million to support Maple's Infrastructure Trust's growth ambitions

"Five years ago, we entered India's roads sector with a single asset and a conviction in the market's long-term potential. Since then, Maple has grown into one of the country's leading road platforms," said Emmanuel Jacot, executive vice-president and head of Infrastructure and Sustainability at La Caisse.

La Caisse, a global investment firm based in Quebec, is active in the major financial markets, private equity, infrastructure, real estate, and private credit. As of 30 June 2026, it held CAD 552 billion in net assets.

MAM, part of Macquarie Group, manages \$498 billion in assets and has a diversified global financial service group operating in asset management, retail and business banking, wealth management, as well as advisory, and risk and capital solutions across debt, equity, financial markets and commodities.

Shake-up at InsuranceDekho

Priyamvada C & Sneha Shah
MUMBAI

InsuranceDekho co-founders Ankit Agrawal and Ish Babbar have expressed their intent to step down from the IPO-bound company over strategic differences with some members of the board, people familiar with the matter said. "There have been some mediations happening to retain the founders in some capacity over the last month. The thought process is that the business needs professional management where the founders must move to the promoter role eventually," one of the people said.

The second person added that the focus is now on the pre-initial public offering (IPO) round of about ₹100-150 crore. "This round will happen at the same valuation as the last round and high net worth individuals, ultra-high net worth individuals and family offices are being approached," the person added.

The company is now expected to file its draft red herring prospectus with the market regulator in the coming weeks to raise about ₹2,500 crore to ₹3,000 crore through a mix of a primary capital raise and secondary share sales by existing investors.

In 2025, the company raised \$70 million in the latest funding round, which was co-led by private equity fund Beams Fintech Fund, Japan's Mitsubishi UFJ Financial Group (MUFG) and insurer BNP Paribas Car-



The focus is now on the pre-IPO round of about ₹100-150 crore. ISTOCKPHOTO

dif via its insurtech fund managed by European investment major Eurazeo.

The development assumes importance as InsuranceDekho just completed one of the largest mergers in the segment with RenewBuy and is headed for a public listing over the next year.

A company spokesperson said these claims are entirely baseless. "The co-founders remain actively involved with InsuranceDekho and continue to lead the company's strategy and growth alongside the broader leadership team. There has been no

change in their roles or their commitment to the company," the spokesperson said.

Founded in 2017 by Agrawal and Babbar, InsuranceDekho earns about 82% of its premium from tier-II cities and beyond. It claims to be present in about 1,500 towns and competes with Acko, Turtlemint and PolicyBazaar.

InsuranceDekho is a subsidiary of automobile portal CarDekho, which pivoted from selling used vehicles to vehicle financing. Jaipur-based Cardekho, which became a unicorn in 2021 with a valuation exceeding \$1

billion, competes with CarTrade, Spinny and Cars24. In December 2023, it acquired shared mobility startup Revv.

On 1 September, InsuranceDekho announced the consolidation of its businesses with RenewBuy to create a unified, pan-India insurance distribution ecosystem. The combined entity was India's largest AI-enabled insurance distribution platform, in terms of point of sales person-driven insurance premium generated, in FY26, the companies said.

Together, the two platforms have facilitated the issuance of over 20 million insurance policies since inception as of 31 March 2026, according to the statement. The combined platform pairs InsuranceDekho's strength across northern and western India with RenewBuy's presence in the south, creating pan-India breadth and depth.

With a premium book exceeding ₹6,600 crore, a network of over 600,000 digital partners, and reach across 98.57% of India's pin codes as of 31 March, the combined entity seeks to ensure partners in smaller towns have the same access to products, tools and support as those in metros.

InsuranceDekho's portfolio spans motor, health, life, travel, and corporate insurance, offering 750+ insurance products from 52 insurers.

Since inception, the company has raised over \$350 million and counts Beams Fintech Fund, Goldman Sachs Asset Management, Avataar Ventures, LeapFrog Investments, TVS Capital Funds and Investcorp among its investors.

Gimar Insurance Brokers Pvt. Ltd, which operates InsuranceDekho, reported an operating income of ₹1,290 crore in FY25 from ₹743.6 crore a year earlier. It posted a loss of ₹47.5 crore as compared to a net profit of ₹85.7 crore in FY24, according to documents sourced by Tofler from the ministry of corporate affairs.

The integration is designed to create an AI-first, distribution-plus-technology flywheel. InsuranceDekho has focused on the use of artificial intelligence in insurance distribution through in-house tools that give partners real time plan

recommendations. Combined with RenewBuy's technology strengths, the platform will support automated partner onboarding. It will operate as an open, multi-insurer ecosystem—enabling choice across motor, health, life and commercial insurance, backed by integrated digital onboarding, policy issuance and AI-powered advisory, the company said on 1 September.

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TOP-LEVEL REJIG

THERE have been discussions to retain the founders in some capacity over the past month

THE thinking is that the founders must eventually transition to promoter roles

Essar to buy UK's SGN Retail Solar Industries bids \$1.4 bn for South Africa's Omnia Holdings

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NEW DELHI

Essar Energy Transition's retail arm has agreed to acquire independent UK forecourt operator SGN Retail in a deal estimated at about £400 million, adding 118 sites to its network and creating a 235-site estate as it seeks to build a vertically integrated fuel business in Britain.

EET Retail, the retail division of Essar Energy Transition Fuels, in a statement said it had agreed to acquire 100% of SGN Retail, which was founded by Graham Peacock and Susan Tobbell.

While the company did not disclose the financial details, sources said the deal is estimated to be about £400 million.

The deal will give EET Retail annual fuel throughput of more than 650 million litres, combining SGN Retail's 118 locations with the 117 sites already operated by EET Retail.



The deal adds 118 sites to EET Retail's network in the UK.

EET Retail said the enlarged network would make it the UK's second-largest forecourt operator with direct integration into fuel production. It plans to expand the network to about 800 sites by 2031, equivalent to roughly 9 per cent of the UK market, with fuel supplied by Essar's Stanlow refinery in Cheshire.

"Building a scaled, vertically integrated retail forecourt platform is a critical pillar of our long-term UK strategy. SGN Retail is one of the high-

est-quality forecourt networks in the UK well ahead of the market. This acquisition accelerates our plan to build a nationwide, vertically integrated platform of 800 sites, backed by direct refinery supply and delivering competitive prices at the pump for UK motorists," said Arvan Ruia, chief executive officer (CEO) of EET Retail.

The acquisition comes as EET seeks to reconnect fuel production with retail distribution, arguing that the UK's fuel market has become increasingly fragmented over the past two decades as oil majors reduced investment in domestic refining.

EET said the model would allow fuel refined at Stanlow to be distributed more directly to its own forecourts, reducing reliance on imports and multiple layers in the domestic supply chain.

The acquisition is part of Essar Energy Transition's broader plan to expand presence across the UK energy supply chain.

Bloomberg
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Solar Industries India Ltd. agreed to acquire South African industrial explosives and fertilizer firm Omnia Holdings Ltd for 21.8 billion rand (\$1.4 billion), seeking to expand in the continent's mining and agriculture industries.

The Nagpur, India-based company offered 134.5 rand per share, a 14.3% premium to Friday's closing price. Omnia surged as much as 7.5% on Monday and traded 4.2% higher at 9.20 am in Johannesburg, giving it a market value of 19.8 billion rand.

For Solar Industries, led by billionaire Satyanarayan Nuwal, the acquisition will be its latest in South Africa, where it controls Problast BS Ltd.

The purchase will help the Indian firm expand across southern Africa and get access to Omnia's facilities in Canada, Brazil, Australia and Indonesia,



Seelan Gobalsamy, CEO, Omnia Holdings.

Omnia chief executive officer (CEO) Seelan Gobalsamy said. "The deal is about growth," Gobalsamy said in an interview on Monday. "It's about accelerating growth to put balance sheets together."

Shares of Solar have surged more than 80% this year, valuing the firm at ₹2.02 trillion (\$21.1 billion).

Solar already has operations

in Ghana, Nigeria, Tanzania and Zambia. Buying Johannesburg-based Omnia gives it access to South Africa, which is home to the world's biggest platinum mines, is the continent's biggest corn grower and the largest global exporter of citrus.

The Indian firm has "immense technology" such as drones and autonomous robotics that can assist Omnia in its agriculture and mining businesses, said Gobalsamy.

"We are accelerating our agribusiness in Australia to all parts of the world—that is a biologicals business focused on crop health," said Gobalsamy. "We see this opportunity to grow that even faster."

Solar has a very strong position in India that could help us," he said.

Omnia's earnings climbed 21% in the year through March, with operating profit roughly split between its mining and agricultural units.



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भारतीय रिज़र्व बैंक
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Appointment of Director, Indian Institute of Bank Management (IIBM), Guwahati - 2026

Applications for the post of Director for Indian Institute of Bank Management (IIBM), Guwahati are invited from seasoned bankers, distinguished professionals, policy makers and academic administrators. The appointment shall be initially for a term of three years and extendable up to five years, subject to satisfactory annual review. The other terms and conditions of appointment are detailed in the advertisement placed on the websites of RBI (www.rbi.org.in) and IIBM (www.iibm.ac.in). Qualified and interested applicants should submit their application on or before October 05, 2026 through online form available on the official website of IIBM, Guwahati (<https://iibm.ac.in>). Received applications shall be treated with confidentiality. The selection process will be steered by a Selection Committee (SC). SC reserves the right to call for applications by invitation for outstanding candidates.

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S&P BSE Sensex	Nifty 50	Nifty 500	Nifty Next 50	Nifty 100	S&P BSE Mid-cap	S&P BSE Small Cap
CLOSE 74781.76	CLOSE 23398.1	CLOSE 22866.5	CLOSE 72083.7	CLOSE 24546.55	CLOSE 16859.15	CLOSE 7225.69
1-WEEK CHANGE (%) -1.77	1-WEEK CHANGE (%) -1.60	1-WEEK CHANGE (%) -1.25	1-WEEK CHANGE (%) -0.68	1-WEEK CHANGE (%) -1.43	1-WEEK CHANGE (%) -0.80	1-WEEK CHANGE (%) -0.74
1-MONTH CHANGE (%) -4.12	1-MONTH CHANGE (%) -3.94	1-MONTH CHANGE (%) -3.05	1-MONTH CHANGE (%) -3.20	1-MONTH CHANGE (%) -3.80	1-MONTH CHANGE (%) -2.36	1-MONTH CHANGE (%) 0.25
3-MONTH CHANGE (%) -0.37	3-MONTH CHANGE (%) -0.35	3-MONTH CHANGE (%) 1.70	3-MONTH CHANGE (%) 3.38	3-MONTH CHANGE (%) 0.34	3-MONTH CHANGE (%) 4.30	3-MONTH CHANGE (%) 6.75
6-MONTH CHANGE (%) 1.40	6-MONTH CHANGE (%) 2.10	6-MONTH CHANGE (%) 7.81	6-MONTH CHANGE (%) 12.42	6-MONTH CHANGE (%) 3.95	6-MONTH CHANGE (%) 14.23	6-MONTH CHANGE (%) 23.62
1-YEAR CHANGE (%) -7.37	1-YEAR CHANGE (%) -5.51	1-YEAR CHANGE (%) -0.18	1-YEAR CHANGE (%) 7.25	1-YEAR CHANGE (%) -3.30	1-YEAR CHANGE (%) 5.46	1-YEAR CHANGE (%) 6.08

NSE-BSE growth gap needs a look

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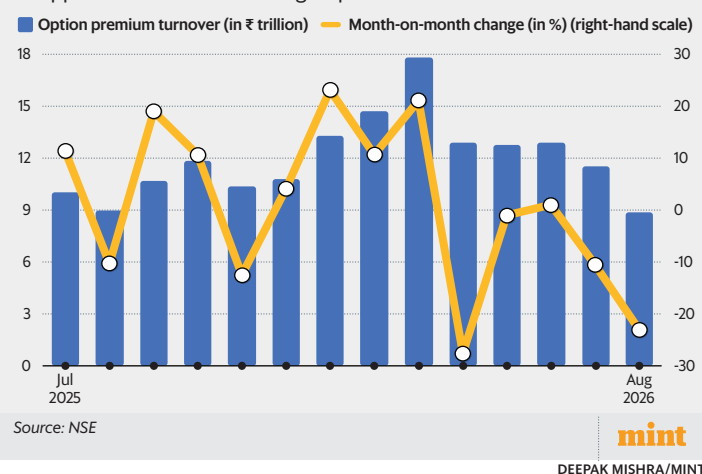
National Stock Exchange of India Ltd (NSE) offer-for-sale (OFS) issue pricing comes as a rude shock to investors buying the shares in the unlisted market. The price band of ₹1,700-1,785 is nearly 10% lower than the price before the announcement.

Given the bearish tone in leading equity benchmarks and a large issue of ₹22,560 crore, NSE's management may have thought of making pricing attractive. The stock's price-to-earnings (P/E) multiple, based on FY26 earnings is 43—a steep 23% discount to BSE's 56. This may seem tempting for investors, but looking at valuation based on FY26 earnings may not give a true picture, given NSE's far slower year-on-year net profit growth of 11% for the June quarter (Q1FY27), versus 65% for BSE. The trend is likely to continue in FY27, based on trading volume data in Q2FY27 so far.

Though NSE remains the leader across cash and derivatives trading volumes, the bigger size alone may

Lull period

NSE's option premium turnover in Q2FY27 could disappoint for the second straight quarter.



not justify valuation premium. Moreover, unlike NSE, BSE has several levers to boost its financial performance.

BSE's option transaction charges are lower at ₹3,250 per ₹1 crore versus ₹3,550 per ₹1 crore for NSE. So, if BSE decides to hike charges, its revenue could rise. Also, falling futures volumes hurt NSE's income, whereas

BSE is immune. This is because NSE charges ₹183 per ₹1 crore of index futures and stock futures transaction, but BSE has kept it free to attract volumes. So, BSE could levy transaction charges on futures to grow net profit.

There is ample room for BSE to gain share in the cash market, where NSE still commands a dominant 93%

share according to Q1FY27 data. The opportunity mirrors BSE's success in derivatives, where its share rose from virtually nil in FY23 to 28% in FY26.

For now, transaction charges remain the single-largest revenue stream for NSE and BSE, contributing nearly 84% and 78%, respectively, of their Q1FY27 operating revenues. Thus, it helps to look at trends mainly in equity derivatives trading volumes to assess the growth trajectory. BSE's option premium turnover in Q1FY27 almost doubled on-year to ₹18 trillion, while NSE's grew by just 14% to ₹39 trillion. Q2FY27 trends are also in favour of BSE. Cumulative figures for July and August show 61% on-year growth in option premium turnover for BSE, versus a mere 7% for NSE.

What can turn the tide in favour of NSE? Besides regaining the growth momentum in equity derivatives, it can make efforts to diversifying its revenue stream. Though income

from data services contributed around 11% of Q1FY27 revenue, the dependence on transaction charges is still higher than global peers.

Global peers such as Nasdaq, London Stock Exchange, Japan Exchange Group, Hong Kong Exchange and Intercontinental Exchange derive only 20-60% of revenue from transaction charges, according to a PL Capital report. A much larger share of their income comes from relatively stable, annuity-like businesses such as market data, technology services and information products. Despite this, most of them trade at 17-22 P/E multiple, based on Bloomberg consensus estimates for CY26

(almost equivalent to FY27)—a large discount to NSE's valuation.

Given this, further expansion in the already-premium multiples of NSE can be tough. So, investors looking to participate in the OFS should note the stock price gains will hinge more on future earnings growth.

NUMBERS DILEMMA

NSE's P/E multiple, based on FY26 earnings is 43—a steep 23% discount to BSE's 56

THIS may seem tempting, but valuation based on FY26 results may not give a true picture

Waaree Renewable's data-centre push raises the stakes

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Waaree Renewable Technologies Ltd (WRTL) announced on Saturday that its subsidiary Waaree Green Data Centers has incorporated subsidiary, Sunstar Data Centers, to develop, finance, own and operate hyperscale, AI-ready and edge data centres.

WRTL had announced in August that Waaree Green would be moved into Waaree Energies, the holding company of WRTL. This means Sunstar is expected to eventually be a step-down subsidiary

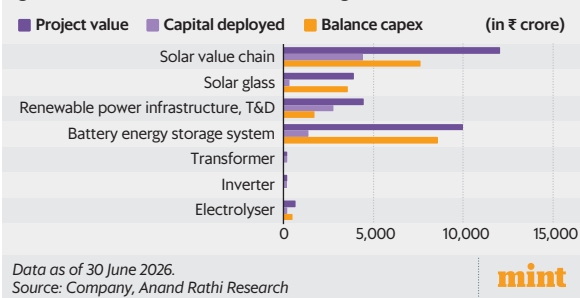
under Waaree Energies.

India's data-centre capacity is expected to rise from 1.6GW in mid-2026 to 6GW by 2029, according to real-estate advisory firm JLL. AI makes the opportunity even more compelling: WRTL management estimates that AI-driven facilities require at least 10 times more power than conventional data centres.

This could prove to be right up Waaree's alley. The group is into solar power generation, and is expanding into transmission and storage. It acquired 55% of Associated Power Structures in June, adding transmission and dis-

Integrated power play

Waaree Energies' pipeline has projects across energy generation, transmission, and storage.



tribution (T&D) capabilities, while battery energy storage system (BESS) is emerging as another growth engine.

WRTL's June-quarter (Q1FY27) bidding pipeline included over 10GW of BESS and ₹20,000 crore of T&D

opportunities. Q1 revenues grew 53% year-on-year to ₹925 crore, while net profit was up 38% to ₹120 crore.

Renewable power could potentially provide the reliable, clean power that data centres need. Waaree's data-centre entry is thus a move further downstream—from building grid-connected renewable assets to developing, owning and operating data centres.

But WRTL has said it is pursuing engineering, procurement and construction (EPC) opportunities in data centres, with no firm data-centre orders as of July. Sunstar is newly incorporated and is yet

to commence operations.

The group is already undertaking a large investment cycle. Waaree Energies has ₹31,500 crore of announced projects, with ₹22,000 crore to be deployed by FY29. Adding data centres, which are capital-intensive, could further stretch capital and execution bandwidth.

After dropping roughly 25% in a year, Waaree Energies stock trades at 8.6 times EV/Ebitda, based on FY28 Bloomberg estimates. While the data-centre boom presents a massive opportunity, market sentiment will hinge on execution.

Mark to Market writers do not hold positions in the companies discussed here unless otherwise informed

Europe's stock market gets single data feed 'Gold prices may witness another rally'

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Europe's protracted efforts to turn its most maligned markets into a more attractive proposition for investors reach a momentous juncture on Monday: the arrival of a consolidated tape.

The fragmentation of trading across venues is often blamed for the view that markets in Europe have lower liquidity versus the US, which introduced a country-wide tape five decades ago. Regulators hope the rollout of a unified feed of prices and trading across 29 countries' markets will start changing perceptions.

Besides issues like diverging legal systems and patchy settlement infrastructure, the European Union has identified piecemeal trading data as one reason investors see the bloc as multiple different markets rather than a single unified one. The tape aims to counter that view by displaying supply and demand data for company shares and exchange-traded funds across the region.

The tape, run by EuroCTP BV, a body backed by Europe's exchanges, won't be just for professional investors and traders. Retail investors can also subscribe via a website, helping to level the playing field with larger institutions.

"Am I excited for Monday? Yes, from a symbolic standpoint," said Alexandre Roubaud, head of ETF markets at BlackRock Inc. in Europe, the Middle East and Africa. "Will we see the benefit of the tape overnight? Certainly not."

It's been a slog getting here,



Regulators hope the rollout of a unified feed of prices and trading across 29 countries' markets will start changing perceptions. REUTERS

almost 20 years since the EU broke up stock exchanges' grip on trading. In that time, there have been plenty of delays and arguments as countries and industries fought to protect their corners in the change.

While Monday's unveiling marks a moment, it isn't like flicking a light switch. EuroCTP needs to get people to sign up to and trust the product, and only time will tell whether it can shift perceptions of Europe's capital markets and lead to better outcomes for investors and companies.

Unlike the US tape, the EU's will offer best bid and ask prices for a particular security without disclosing the trading venue that generated the quotes. Instead, market participants will see more granular data after a transaction has taken place. That's sparked

criticism from banking and asset management associations, who argue that won't be good enough for members to trade on.

Just over half of respondents to a recent Bloomberg Intelligence survey of 108 senior buy-side traders said they planned to access the EU tape

either directly from EuroCTP or third-party providers. Only a fifth thought it could reduce their reliance on direct data feeds from stock exchanges.

Eleanor Beasley, chief operating officer for Goldman Sachs' EMEA equities business, says the fastest moving investors may not use it for trading at first as they assess the data, but there are still benefits.

"It is a really useful tool to improve the understanding of the total traded volume," she

said. "If you're a company looking to list or are listed in the region and you think the only volume that trades in your name is on the primary market, I think that this will give you a much better idea as to the total traded volume."

Goldman Sachs will contribute to the tape by supplying data from its Sigma X Europe trading venue, as well as consuming data from the feed through its trading operation. Bloomberg LP, the parent of Bloomberg News, aggregates and distributes trading data throughout Europe.

A consolidated tape is a single feed that aggregates data across multiple execution venues for equity trading.

In Europe, trading is split across different venues, including primary exchanges like Euronext, alternative venues like Cboe Europe, investment bank trading desks known as systematic internalizers and so-called dark pools.

Currently, it's difficult to see the total volume of trading across all of these venues, a problem the consolidated tape is intended to rectify.

Within the tape there are two types: pre-trade and post-trade. A post-trade tape collects all of the data about trades after they have been executed. A pre-trade tape, however, shows the offers to buy or sell a security before they are made.

A pre-trade tape may have different levels of depth to it. The most simple will show an aggregated feed of buy and sell orders across all venues. This is the type that will go into effect on Monday.

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Gold prices could be at the start of yet another rally, a top Standard Chartered investment official said, as central banks stock up, US dollar weakens and the dollar yield curve steepens.

"We believe this is the start of another rally in gold prices," said Manpreet Gill, chief investment officer, Africa, Middle East & Europe at Standard Chartered, pointing to gold recently breaking out of the \$4,000-level.

Gill remains overweight and bullish on gold, expecting it to approach \$5,000 over six to 12 months.

Gold prices have surged around 70% from ₹76,308 per 10 grams on 1 January 2025 to ₹1,53,045 now.

Gill sees central-bank demand as the bigger story. While buying can ebb and flow, central banks tend to be more price-sensitive than investors might expect, often stepping in when prices cool rather than when they are rising sharply. "The big one is still that central banks are buying," he said, adding that interest rates and momentum are more tactical factors.

While it is hard to know where this trend eventually ends, Gill sees room for the diversification trade to continue.

Silver, however, is a different story. Its extensive industrial use links it closer to the economic cycle, offering less of gold's hedging properties. It is also a smaller and considera-



Manpreet Gill, chief investment officer, Africa, Middle East & Europe, Standard Chartered.

bly more volatile market, he said. Standard Chartered has no silver exposure in its model portfolio and, while it has considered the metal as an opportunistic trade when the gold-silver ratio moves to extremes, Gill sees gold mining equities as a better risk-reward option for now.

In equities, the US and Asia ex-Japan are Standard Chartered's top-ranked markets. Within Asia, Taiwan and China equities are Overweight, with Indian equities as a Neutral or core holding. In bonds, emerging-market US dollar bonds are the top preference, given their relatively low sensitivity to oil prices.

The bank is maintaining a balance between being Overweight Taiwan equities and Neutral Indian markets as val-

Rothschild to help Victura Group with \$300-400mn IPO

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MUMBAI

Faridabad-based Victura Group, which makes components for the auto sector, has picked Rothschild as an advisor to oversee its public listing process that could raise as much as \$300-400 million, two people familiar with the development said.

"Rothschild has been roped in as an independent advisor to help with the listing process. Victura has held initial discussions with merchant bankers and is expected to make appointments over the coming months for a potential listing later next year," one of the two people said on condition of anonymity.

If it goes as planned, Victura will join the growing list of other auto component makers such as Hero Motors and Dhoot Transmission that have gone public this year. Mint also reported that Bain-backed RSB Transmissions has kicked

off a process for a public listing. The listing will likely be a mix of primary capital raise and secondary share sale by existing shareholders, the second person added. The firm is likely to use the proceeds from the IPO to expand operations, as the promoters look to pare some of their stake.

Mint's queries emailed to Rothschild and Victura Group remained unanswered. Established in 1972 by the Banga family, Victura manufactures and supplies automotive, sheet metal components, automotive seat frames, exhaust system components, stampings, exhaust hangers and pressure pipes, forged components, CNC and machined components.

such as Uno Minda, Mother-son Group, Varroc Engineering, JBM Group and Indo Autotech. Victura's major customers are Maruti Suzuki India Ltd, Tata Motors Ltd, Mahindra & Mahindra Ltd, JCB Group, International Tractors Ltd, FCC Group, Plastic Omnium Auto Energy (export market), Adient India Pvt. Ltd, Rane NSK, etc., according to an August Cirsil report.

In FY25, it reported an operating revenue of ₹3,284.95 crore compared with ₹2,900 crore a year ago. Its net profit also rose to ₹278.85 crore from ₹250.84 crore in FY24, according to documents sourced by Tofler from the corporate affairs ministry.

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Victura is likely to use proceeds for expansion. ISTOCKPHOTO

The company, which set up its first plant in Faridabad, has expanded to five other states and 10 warehousing centres across the US, Mexico, the Czech Republic, South Africa and Europe, according to its official website. Its clients include original equipment manufacturers in the PV, 2V, tractor, agricultural and construction equipment segments.

It competes with major automotive component and metal engineering manufacturers

such as Uno Minda, Mother-son Group, Varroc Engineering, JBM Group and Indo Autotech.

Victura's major customers are Maruti Suzuki India Ltd, Tata Motors Ltd,

Mahindra & Mahindra Ltd, JCB Group, International Tractors Ltd, FCC Group, Plastic Omnium Auto Energy (export market), Adient India Pvt. Ltd, Rane NSK, etc., according to an August Cirsil report.

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More small businesses turn to LLPs to ease compliance

The cumulative number of companies converted to LLPs nearly doubled to 29,816 as of June

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A growing number of small businesses are converting their companies into limited liability partnerships (LLPs), seeking lower compliance costs and greater flexibility in how they operate.

The cumulative number of companies converted to LLPs nearly doubled to 29,816 as of June from 15,716 five years earlier, according to corporate affairs ministry data reviewed by *Mint*.

The conversions, involving mainly small, closely held businesses, also reflect their lower capital-raising needs, analysts said. Companies generally have an easier time raising funds than LLPs.

LLPs typically have fewer compliance requirements to meet than even small companies, given their limited financial muscle and exposure. They are subject mainly to two filings—an annual return and a yearly statement of account and solvency—with no compulsory board or annual general meetings and no mandatory statutory audit if their turnover is below ₹40 lakh and their capital contribution is lower than ₹25 lakh. A small company is defined as one with paid-up share capital of up to ₹10 crore and annual turnover of up to ₹100 crore. It cannot be a public company.

Fresh company and LLP registrations have surged in recent years, although the cumulative number of active companies in India—2.13 million as of June—is more than four times the roughly half-a-million LLPs. Between April and August, 110,748 new companies were registered, the highest for the first five months of any fiscal year and up 12% on



The conversions also point to lower capital-raising needs, as companies can garner funds more easily than LLPs.

ISTOCKPHOTO

year, as per the ministry's data. LLP registrations jumped 31.1% to 48,972. In the year through June, 2,164 companies switched to LLPs, including 688 between April and June.

"The conversions (into LLPs) are mainly concentrated among closely-

aging partner at law firm Kings & Alliance LLP.

Queries emailed to the corporate affairs ministry remained unanswered until press time.

For a small entrepreneur, the cost of maintaining a company can be high,

agree on how the business is managed and how profits are shared with less paperwork," he said.

For a business run by a family or a few individuals, with no immediate plan to bring in outside equity investors, an LLP can be a better fit, Agrawal said. Moreover, an LLP pays tax on its income, but partners' profits are generally exempt in their hands. Company dividends, however, are generally taxable for shareholders. "This can favour an LLP where owners regularly distribute profits. Therefore, for many small businesses, the appeal is practical as the LLP structure requires less time on corporate housekeeping and more time on customers and growth," Agarwal said.

Currently, even a small company has to hold board meetings, convene an annual general meeting, maintain registers, file financial statements and annual returns, and undergo statutory audits every year. For an LLP, barring an annual return and a yearly statement of account and solvency, these compliances are not required.

"Similarly, a company pays tax on profits; the shareholder then pays tax again on the dividend, with tax deducted at source under Section 194 of the income tax law. An LLP is taxed as a firm at 30% plus surcharge and cess," said Chaudhary of Kings & Alliance LLP.

The partner's profit share is exempted under Section 10(2A) of the income tax law, and working-partner remuneration is deductible under Section 40(b).

"For a profitable business that distributes rather than reinvests, the LLP is the cleaner vehicle which is why lawyers, doctors, consultants and family shops convert, not venture-backed start-ups," Chaudhary said.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Tata Steel taps Lloyds Metals JV unit to run Odisha mine

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Deepening its partnership with Lloyds Metals and Energy Ltd, Tata Steel has tapped Brahmani River Pellets Ltd (BRPL) to develop and operate its manganese mines, according to two people familiar with the matter.

The steelmaker has awarded the Joda West mine in Odisha to BRPL and if it achieves the required operational efficiency, Tata Steel could consider awarding its other mines to the company, one person said, requesting anonymity.

BRPL is fully owned by Thriveni Pellets Pvt. Ltd, in which Tata Steel holds a 50.01% stake, with the rest held by Lloyds Metals.

Tata Steel has a total manganese ore capacity of about 300,000 tonnes a year across its Tiringpahar, Bamebari, Joda West and Khondbond mines. These mining leases are set to expire in 2030, according to Big-Mint, a commodities market intelligence firm. Manganese ore, a hard silvery-gray metal, is used to improve the strength, hardness and toughness of steel.

"The new MDO for the Joda West Manganese Mines is Brahmani River Pellets Ltd (BRPL), a subsidiary of Tata Steel (Tata Steel Ltd owns 50.01% and Lloyds Metals & Energy Ltd owns 49.99%)." BRPL brings together the mining expertise and operational capabilities of both organizations," a Tata Steel spokesperson said in an email response to *Mint*'s queries.



Tata Steel has stepped up its partnership with Lloyds Metals as it looks to secure access to key raw materials.

BLOOMBERG

"Tata Steel works with a pool of registered MDOs, of which BRPL is one. The selection of MDOs is an operating decision and is undertaken in accordance with the Company's procurement process and based on their competitiveness. As Tata Steel continues to expand its mining operations, the Company is leveraging a combination of approaches—own/departmental mining and the MDO model—to optimize resources and capital expenditure," the spokesperson said.

As Tata Steel expands its mining operations, the company is leveraging a combination of approaches—own/departmental mining and the

MDO model—to optimize resources and capital expenditure, the spokesperson said.

"The MDO is being pursued through Brahmani River Pellets Ltd (BRPL), a JV of Lloyds Metals & Tata Steel, in which the latter holds 50.01%," said a Lloyds spokesperson confirming the MDO contract.

Tata Steel already meets its manganese requirement internally, said Dhruv Goel,

CEO of BigMint. Normal steel also requires some level of manganese alloy, but higher manganese content is needed for specialized grades such as high-tensile and high-corrosion-resistant steel. About 15kg of manganese is used for every tonne of steel, said Goel.

Tata Steel has stepped up its partnership with Lloyds Metals as it looks to secure access to key raw materials and strengthen its mining and steelmaking operations. The Mumbai-based steelmaker signed a memorandum of understanding with Lloyds Metals & Energy in December to explore mining opportunities in Maharashtra, with a focus on increasing iron ore production, a key raw material for steelmaking.

The partnership extends beyond raw materials and mining. Tata Steel and Lloyds Metals are exploring the development of a greenfield steel plant with a capacity of 6 million tonnes a year in Maharashtra, to be developed in two phases.

The proposed project would give Tata Steel a deeper presence in the state while allowing the companies to leverage their combined expertise in mining, iron ore processing and steelmaking.

Villas, apartments in Elivaas portfolio

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Elivaas, a three-year-old vacation rental platform, is adding villas and apartment complexes to its portfolio of individual holiday homes to differentiate itself from the growing pool of holiday-home operators.

The Gurugram-based company, which manages more than 800 properties, is betting the expansion will allow it to add hundreds of units through a single developer or homeowner partnership, rather than acquiring properties one at a time.

It has signed a pipeline of about 1,100 units expected to come under its management over the next two years. The hospitality startup is also raising ₹200-250 crore to expand from 55 cities to 1,200 properties by March 2027, founder and chief executive Ritwik Khare told *Mint*.

The company, officially Ishanee Villas Tech Pvt. Ltd, last raised ₹87 crore in a Series B round, led by Vertex Ventures Southeast Asia and India in August 2025, with existing investors Peak XV Partners'



Elivaas has signed a pipeline of about 1,100 units expected to come under its management over the next two years.

Surge and 3one4 Capital also participating. It previously raised \$5 million (about ₹42 crore) in Series A funding in September 2024. The business was founded by Khare and Karan Miglani in 2023.

"Most second-home owners are struggling to maintain and monetize properties when they are not using them. The Real Estate Regulatory Authority (Rera) has 600,000 units. We are identifying a huge pool of this newly constructed inventory that

could potentially be managed as holiday-home stock," he said.

Elivaas is also expanding beyond northern India. This month, it signed a 12-unit project on Tamil Nadu's East Coast Road (Mahabalipuram) and a project with Mumbai-based real estate developer Shree Naman Group in Pawna. It has properties in Lonavala, Ali-baug and Karjat in Maharashtra. It is also adding destinations in Coorg, Chikkamagaluru and the outskirts of

Bengaluru in Karnataka, as well as Varkala, Wayanad, Alleppey and Munnar in Kerala, as demand for professionally managed holiday homes expands beyond its existing markets.

The model is now being stretched beyond individual homes, with developers and homeowners increasingly bringing multiple units into a project, enabling collective management of areas to be developed as blocks of hospitality inventory.

"We have the responsibility for housekeeping, maintenance, staffing, guest services, food, distribution and revenue management and are working with developers and complex owners to manage entire societies of holiday homes and adding abilities for homeowners to monetize with things like food and beverage and spas, etc. in the same area," said Khare.

The idea is to have the consistency of a hotel, he added. "Quite a lot of holiday makers would prefer a holiday home if they knew they were getting trusted brands such as Marriott or Hilton for villas."

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Young investors are driving next disruption wave in broking: Z47

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India's broking industry is entering another cycle of disruption as younger investors embrace new platforms, creating room for a new generation of brokers to build large businesses, according to Anish Patil, an investor at venture capital firm Z47.

"Broking is one of the few categories where every five years, if you go and see the winners, they change," Anish said in an interview with *Mint*, on the sidelines of the Global Fintech Fest. The shift is being driven by technological advances and generational change, he said. New investors tend to enter the market through newer platforms, while technology allows emerging brokers to operate with leaner cost structures and better economics.

The underlying market is expanding too. India's securities brokerage market, valued at \$6.98 billion in 2026, is projected to grow at a CAGR of 13.33% to \$13.09 billion by



Anish Patil, an investor at venture capital firm Z47.

2031, according to a July Morning Intelligence report.

Anish does not expect newer brokers to simply displace established players. India's expanding investor base, he said, is large enough to accommodate several businesses, including those built around specific customer segments. "There is enough space for 10 brokers to coexist, as retail participation in the equity capital markets continues to deepen," he said.

While some newer brokers are building products for active traders, others are zeroing in on

younger investors. A broker does not necessarily need tens of millions of users to build a sizeable business; a smaller but highly engaged customer base can also support a viable model, Anish said. The opportunity comes amid a broader deepening of India's wealth market. Z47, formerly Matrix Partners India, has been seeing a new wave of wealth-tech startups emerge as more Indians accumulate wealth, its managing director Vikram Vaidyanathan told *Mint* in 2025.

In July 2025, *Mint* reported that the Bengaluru-based firm, which split from US parent Matrix in 2024, was in early talks to raise its first fund for investing in Indian startups. Its portfolio includes OneCard, Captain Fresh, Country Delight, Jupiter, MoEngage and Zupee, while it has also explored AI-led financial services. It has exited investments such as Avail, CreditVidya, Five Star Business Finance, ITZ Cash, Muthoot Finance and Ola Electric through strategic sales and public listings.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Phone makers seek 13% GST cut as demand declines

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Mobile phone industry body ICEA has written to the government seeking a reduction in GST on mobile phones to 5% from the current 18% amid a decline in domestic demand, especially due to rising memory chip prices. India Cellular and Electronics Association (ICEA) in a letter to finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman dated 2 September said India is now the world's second-largest mobile-phone manufacturer by volume, and mobile phones became the country's largest export product in FY 2025-26.

The industry body, which represents the majority of mobile phone manufacturers, said domestic demand, however, has not kept pace with manufacturing and exports, as handset consumption has declined, replacement cycles have lengthened and the affordable smartphone segment remains under pressure.

"This imbalance will constrain the next phase of manufacturing growth unless India restores momentum in its domestic market. ICEA therefore seeks the Government's intervention to reduce GST on mobile phones from 18% to 5% and undertake corresponding rationalisation for mobile-phone components," ICEA chairman Pankaj Mohindroo said in the letter.

He said a lower tax rate will reduce the price advantage available to grey-market and informal sellers.

ICEA said smartphone prices for entry-level phones in India increased about 35-45% across brands over the last year while the supply of smartphones priced below ₹10,000 has contracted sharply to less than 5%.

Niche OTT platforms ditch standalone apps, pivot to aggregators

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Warner Bros. Discovery's decision to shut down standalone operations for discovery+, its video streaming service in India, and end direct-to-consumer operations underscores a broader shift: economics no longer favour niche streaming apps in a country dominated by broadcaster-led platforms and global giants such as Netflix and Prime Video, say experts.

The high cost of creating premium content is difficult to recover, particularly as short-form video gains ground. Yet

companies with large content libraries can still monetize them through aggregators and licensing deals.

HOOQ, Spuul and BigFlix either shut down or abandoned originals years ago, while ALTBalaji has scaled back and increasingly licensed its library to rivals.

Going forward, three models are likely to emerge: outright licensing, which offers one-off revenue but little brand or customer data; branded hubs within larger platforms, which retain the brand and offer recurring revenue at minimal local cost; and bundling with telecom, DTH or e-commerce membership platforms, experts said.



The industry is highly competitive with many international, national and regional players.

ISTOCKPHOTO

"We have seen sustained growth of discovery+ through our local partners and have decided to focus on amplifying this reach across these plat-

forms. The discovery+ [India] DTC service will be discontinued from 3 November, but fans can continue to enjoy discovery+ content via partner plat-

forms, including Amazon Prime Video Channels, Jio TV+, Jio TV, Tata Play Binge, Dish TV VZY and Playbox TV."

Warner Bros. Discovery said in a statement in response to *Mint*'s queries.

Rohan Lobo, industry leader for technology, media and telecommunications for Deloitte South Asia, said there will be more OTT platforms that do not survive in India. Competitive advantage and pricing power in India sit at three fronts: scarce rights, distribu-

tion platforms that own the customer and IP that earns across platforms. "Niche apps that don't control a large por-

tion of the three drivers do not have enough pricing power to recover acquisition, payments, and content costs alone. We have seen this earlier with international entrants and creator-led platforms, but I expect more niche apps—domestic and international—to close the standalone app and move content into the distribution platform of a larger

NOT QUITE ECONOMIC

PREMIUM content creation cost is hard to recover, mainly as short-form video gains ground

NICHE streaming apps aren't viable as broadcaster-led platforms, global giants rule India

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(@NewsTG8)

PE majors circle Orbicular stake, value seen at \$1.5 bn

FROM PAGE 1

terals, nasal sprays and inhalations, which characterizes a product domain that is complex, has entry barriers and profitable domain.

Led by M.S. Mohan and Hiren Patel, Orbicular has a team of over 300 scientists focused on establishing a one-stop shop to ensure seamless delivery of highly complex products.

Over the years, it has evolved from an R&D-consultancy service provider into a developer of complex formulations with a focus on niche peptide molecules.

In FY25, the company began commercial production of formulations containing the GLP-1 molecule liraglutide. It currently has two molecules under commercial production: liraglutide and semaglutide. As of March 2026, it has filed over 90 abbreviated new drug application (ANDAs), a few on its own and a few in col-



As of March 2026, Orbicular had filed 90 ANDAs. ISTOCKPHOTO

Orbicular competes with specialty generic and complex formulation developers in India and globally, including companies like Gland Pharma Ltd, Apotex Inc., Dr Reddy's Laboratories and Aurobindo Pharma, as per online reports.

The investor interest comes amid India emerging as world's third-largest pharmaceutical producer by volume and eleventh-

The domestic pharma market, currently valued around \$60 bn, is seen more than doubling to \$130 bn by 2030

largest by value, with more than 3,000 companies and 10,500 manufacturing units, according to a government report in March. India is world's largest supplier of generic medicines, accounting for about 20% of global supply, it added.

The domestic pharma market, currently valued around \$60 billion, is seen more than doubling to \$130 billion by 2030, according to the government report. The sector had recorded a turnover of ₹4.72 trillion in FY25.

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Coforge hires Egon Zehnder after twin exits at top level

Company confident that there won't be any more exits, points to record large deal wins

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BENGALURU

Information technology (IT) services company Coforge Ltd on Monday said it has hired executive search firm Egon Zehnder, after its chairman OP Bhatt and nomination and remuneration panel chairman DK Singh quit in quick succession.

"We are looking for two independent directors, and we will consider for the chair selection, both internal and external candidates. We have already engaged Egon Zehnder, one of the leading global executive search firms, and we have started the process," independent director Vivek Sharma said during the company's analyst call.

Sharma has been tasked with leading a global search to add additional independent directors to the board. He will also oversee the process of electing the new Chair.

The company earlier stated that independent directors Bhatt and Singh withheld parts of the board's governance report from other directors. Bhatt quit on 8 September and Singh two days later. After the two exits, the Coforge board has seven members, with three independent directors—Beth Boucher, Vivek Sharma, and Anil Chanana.

The abrupt exits and the company's disclosures have raised governance concerns and its potential to impact the long-term strategy of the country's fastest-growing tech services firm. Coforge ended last year with \$1.87 billion in revenue, up 29.2% on a yearly basis.

On Monday, the management also stated that the next chairperson will be an independent director among the internal candidates.

"For the selection of the chairperson of the board, we will consider both



The management said the next chairperson will be an independent director.

external candidates, the candidates we are recruiting, as well as internal candidates. And yes, to your question, the internal candidates, we'll only consider the independent directors, which excludes me," said Sharma.

tenure at the company's helm. Two days later, the head of Coforge's nomination and remuneration committee (NRC), D.K. Singh, resigned, citing "differences and tension" between executive and independent directors and a

BOARD CONCERNS

THE abrupt exits and the company's disclosures have raised governance concerns

COFORGE exuded confidence that its business will not be impacted due to the board tussle

COFORGE ended last year with \$1.87 billion in revenue, up 29.2% on a yearly basis

THIS has potential to impact the long-term strategy of the country's fastest-growing tech firm

These disclosures and the call aims to assuage investor concerns.

In his resignation letter, banking veteran Bhatt cited disagreements with the board members over his "good faith actions", ending his 27-month stint

lack of independence to operate as a key reason for his exit. Both Bhatt and Singh were part of NRC, which came under the scanner of the company's internal auditor, KPMG, for allegedly withholding information regarding the

FSSAI scrutiny puts food claims in focus

FROM PAGE 1

claim was high absorption. Our first questions were: Where are your lab tests? Were they conducted independently? Which competing brands did you benchmark against? You cannot compare yourself only with poor-performing brands and call it differentiation. If there isn't enough credible data, we simply say there is no meaningful differentiation."

The scrutiny is also extending to compliance systems.

"Most of the deals I am doing now involve investors asking companies to have a compliance officer. It has become part of the deal because non-compliance can happen for many reasons, whether it is a regulatory filing that has not been done or a licence issue. Investors want someone internally responsible for making sure these things are monitored on an ongoing basis. They are also increasingly conscious of the risk of an FSSAI licence being cancelled, because that can have a direct impact on the business," said Sumeet Seraf, founder, Equity 360, an



India's healthy food market may reach \$59.8 billion by 2034.

investment banking firm.

Seraf said the requirement arose in a D2C protein and other-category brand where the investor wanted to review product labels and understand FSSAI's position on them. "Going forward, given that a lot of You-Tubers are also discussing the same issues, they wanted to have a compliance officer who could take care of the legal aspects and provide other guidance," he said.

Investment bankers say the change reflects a broader shift

in what investors want to verify before putting money into food and wellness brands.

"The diligence process has shifted from verifying licences

D2C brands are responding by strengthening their compliance teams and turning to third parties for audits

and certifications to verifying claims. This shift is more consumer-led because consumers started reading the back of the pack and brands began building entire businesses on a

single claim: organic, then no palm oil, no added sugar, no maida, and now 'real, not processed,' said Namrata Mishra, director of investment bank-

ing firm IndigoEdge.

IndigoEdge has advised D2C brands including beauty marketplace Purpille, beauty brand Foxtale, food brand Anveshan and sustainable-products company Arboreal.

India's healthy food market was valued at \$25.8 billion in 2025 and may reach \$59.8 billion by 2034, expanding at a compound annual growth rate of 9.8%, according to IMARC.

D2C brands are responding by strengthening compliance and seeking third-party audits.

"We have an in-house R&D team, and recently we hired more senior people for our compliance and legal compliance functions. We felt that if there are areas where we can become more transparent as a consumer-facing brand, we should improve them rather than simply continuing with what we were already doing. We are thinking about how we can make things better and improve day by day," Amit Tyagi, founder of consumer wellness brand Neuherbs which sells supplements such as Omega-3. The company plans to start its fundraising talks in the next two months.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

FDA's Mundhe prods NPPA for cheaper devices at hospitals

FROM PAGE 1

the Drugs (Prices Control) Order, 2013 (DPCO), according to the 10 August communication, titled "Market Survey Report of purchase and sale price variations in Medical Devices (surgical items used in IPD)," reviewed by *Mint*.

The DPCO, issued by the ministry of chemicals and fertilizers, empowers the NPPA to regulate and enforce statutory ceiling prices for essential medicines and notified medical devices—a list that Mundhe's survey—found excludes many hospital surgical consumables. The NPPA is examining whether manufacturers and intermediary supply channels are adding large markups between wholesale procurement prices and the prices ultimately charged to patients, according to two officials who declined to be named, citing rules. The authority has also received similar representations from drug commissioners in Punjab, Rajasthan and Tamil Nadu, the officials said.

"The NPPA is cross-check-



Tukaram Mundhe seeks review of device pricing rules

ing company filings and internal price lists to assess whether formal margin-capping mechanisms are warranted. We are analyzing our own data and comparing this against the price lists companies file with us," the first official said.

Mundhe said the absence of strict statutory price caps under DPCO 2013 has allowed "unchecked trade-level profiteering" among device manufacturers and distributors. "Unlike scheduled medicines under the Drugs (Prices Control) Order, 2013, many categories of medical devices fall

outside strict statutory price controls, allowing unchecked pricing practices to persist," he wrote, calling for margin rationalisation, an inter-agency review, and guidelines to regulate the permissible gap between trade procurement costs and declared MRPs. "This is not merely a pricing issue; it is a patient-protection issue," Mundhe told *Mint* over the phone, confirming his communication.

"Profitability is essential for hospitals to invest in infrastructure, technology and patient safety. However, it should never come at the cost of transparency or patient trust," said Dr Aashish Chaudhry, managing director at Aakash Healthcare, New Delhi.

Queries emailed to the offices of the ministries of chemicals and health; the NPPA chairman; the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation and FDA chiefs of Rajasthan and Tamil Nadu went unanswered, as did queries emailed to the Punjab state government and FDA commissioner.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com



Telcos alleged that Vi nudged customers to switch networks.

Trai to examine telcos' concerns against Vi

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Amid concerns raised by Bharti Airtel Ltd and Reliance Jio Infocomm Ltd over rival Vodafone Idea Ltd's (Vi) alleged attempt to nudge telecom customers to switch to its network, Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (Trai) chairman A.K. Lahoti on Monday said the regulator will examine representations it has received from the operators.

"When we get representation from any operator, we look into it...they (telcos) have expressed some concerns against each other. We will examine whatever has come," Lahoti said on the sidelines of a Cellular Operators Association of India (Coai) event.

Lahoti, responding to a question on whether Trai is examining the matter raised by Bharti Airtel and Reliance Jio against Vi, however, declined to specify whether all three telecom operators will be called for a detailed discussion or follow-up query on the issue.

When contacted, a Vi spokesperson, in response to a PTI query, said: "At Vi, we believe in fair competition, strength of our products and the value we deliver to our customers. At all times, we conduct our business in compliance with the law".

The comments came in the backdrop of concerns raised by the telcos over rival Vi's alleged practices aimed at nudging customers to switch networks.

Airtel and Jio could not be reached for comments on the issue.

Recently, one of the operators approached Trai over alleged circulation and promotion by Vodafone Idea of tariff benefits specifically linked to customers porting their mobile connections to the Vi network. In a letter, the operator highlighted Trai's past stated position that extending preferential or differential tariff benefits exclusively to customers porting from another network is impermissible and amounts to an inducement for churn.

The letter also urged Trai to direct Vi to immediately cease the circulation of such promotional communications and to submit a compliance report confirming withdrawal of all ads, campaigns and sales practices that link tariff benefits to porting into the Vi network.

India's space boom is creating a new business for lawyers

FROM PAGE 1

said institutional and large domestic and foreign investors are increasingly exploring opportunities in the sector.

"We are witnessing a significant rise in legal mandates from institutional and large investors, both domestic and foreign, who are keen to enter the space sector," Agarwal said. Home-grown unicorns are also looking to participate in requests for proposals (RFPs) issued by ISRO for final product development and operational assistance, he said.

The FDI liberalization has also expanded advisory work, with automatic-route limits of 74% for satellites, 49% for

launch vehicles and spaceports, and 100% for components and subsystems.

The complexity varies with the business. A satellite manufacturer can face a different regulatory regime from a satellite operator, launch company or communications provider. Space mandates can involve FDI, IN-SPACE, Department of Telecommunications (DoT) and Wireless Planning and Coordination Wing (WPC) approvals for spectrum and satellite communications. Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA) compliance, Special Chemicals, Organisms, Materials, Equipment and Technologies export controls, security

clearances, geospatial-data permission and environmental and land-use nod.

"Each of those activities comes with a different set of regulations. The difficult part is often understanding how these regulations interact," said Anirudh Sharma, founder and chief executive of Digan-tara, a space-tech company.

Defence-linked activities may also need defence ministry nod and end-use certification. "Space is a highly capital-intensive, high-risk industry with significant geopolitical and national-security implications," Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas Kumar said.

That makes the work more government-facing, said Shar-



Space mandates can involve FDI, IN-SPACE, DoT and Wireless Planning and Coordination Wing approvals.

ath Chandrasekhar, partner at DSK Legal, who advises on M&A. "Unlike conventional tech businesses, space companies operate in an ecosystem

involving national security, strategic technologies, orbital resources and India's international obligations."

A key complication is dual-

use technology, which can have both civilian and military applications, including satellite imagery, communications, navigation systems and components.

"Dual-use technology particularly requires a lot of management and scrutiny as they have military-use cases," said Bag-misikha Puhan, managing partner at Puhan & Puhan LLP, who has worked in space law for 11 years.

Firms working with foreign customers or using foreign-made components can face

additional scrutiny, she said.

The approval process can also be lengthy. Nikhil Narendran, partner at Trilegal, said

approvals can take six to nine months and sometimes even a year when national-security considerations, multiple ministries and security nodes are involved.

Law firms said they don't yet have dedicated space practices. Mandates are handled by cross-practice teams drawing on M&A/PE, regulatory, TMT, tax, intellectual property and trade/

export-control specialists.

Tejas Bharadwaj, senior research analyst at Carnegie India, said the sector needs greater clarity around newer activities such as in-space servicing, assembly and manufacturing and orbital data centres. Timely guidelines, he said, would help firms attract investment and negotiate international partnerships.

Chandrasekhar sees work getting more sophisticated over next three to five years, as investments, M&A, JVs, tech licences, satellite and launch contracts, insurance, liability, procurement and cross-border deals grow more complex.

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Pfizer makes unusual enemy in \$2bn fight over covid vaccines

Drugmaker targets air-traffic control fees in dispute with Poland and Romania over unwanted covid-19 vaccines

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Pfizer is taking aim at an unusual target in its quest to get paid for millions of unwanted Covid-19 vaccines: air-traffic controllers.

The drug giant has pursued European governments seeking to enforce pandemic-era contracts to buy billions of dollars' worth of vaccines that haven't yet been made and are no longer needed. In April, it won a year-long legal fight to hold Poland and Romania to deals for more than 90 million shots.

To recoup the \$2.2 billion owed, Pfizer is going after money used to pay air-traffic controllers. In July, it won court approval to place a lien on fees airlines pay to access the countries' airspace.

The dispute is one of the strangest legal battles to emerge from the dark days of the pandemic and shows the unconventional tactics companies deploy when trying to collect from governments. Pfizer's move has sparked criticism from Poland and Romania's air-navigation agencies, which accuse the company of jeopardizing air safety.

"Airlines are paying for our service and our money is taken as a hostage," said Magdalena Jaworska-Mackowiak, chief executive of the Polish Air Navigation Services Agency. "The court case on vaccines is the state and Pfizer. Nothing to do with aviation."

Pfizer's action cuts off access to funds that account for more than 80% of the air-navigation agency's budget, the CEO said, adding that it would take up to five years to cover the vaccine debt.

Pfizer says its actions are an appropriate and measured response to uphold its contract.

"The court's judgment in favor of Pfizer confirms the importance of the



Pfizer's claim dates back to 2021 when the EU negotiated a landmark deal for hundreds of millions of Covid-19 vaccines. REUTERS

contractual obligations that underpinned a successful European pandemic response," a company spokesman said.

Pfizer's claim dates back to 2021 when the European Union negotiated a landmark agreement to secure hundreds of millions of Covid-19 vaccines on behalf of its 27 member states. As part of the deal, the company made local production and delivery commitments for the shot, which was developed with BioNTech.

But the deal—struck at a time when the world was clamoring for vaccinations—ultimately left Europe with far more shots than it needed.

While other EU countries reached settlements to exit their contracts, Poland and Romania resisted. In early 2022, shortly after Russia invaded Ukraine and with the pandemic easing,

Poland said it could no longer afford to take delivery of 63 million more doses. Romania followed suit shortly after.

The standoff has grabbed national headlines and drawn the ire of politicians and the public. Poland's health minister, Jolanta Sobiechowska-Grenda, compared the sum Pfizer is pursuing—€1.3 billion, equivalent to roughly \$1.5 billion—to the country's annual spend on cancer medications. The pharmaceutical giant is due another €600 million from Romania.

It isn't atypical for companies to go to great lengths to recover money from governments. In 2012, Elliott Investment Management orchestrated the seizure of an Argentine naval ship in a battle over a debt default. In 2021, British oil company Cairn Energy won the right to seize apartments in Paris owned by the

Indian government in a tax dispute.

Air-traffic control fees have been targeted several times in recent years, including in commercial standoffs involving Albania, Bosnia and Herzegovina and Spain.

Unlike in the U.S., where airlines pay the Federal Aviation Administration directly, in Europe the fees are collected by a regional body before being dispersed to individual countries.

That body—the European Organisation for the Safety of Air Navigation, known as Eurocontrol—recently won new protections that prevent companies from targeting its funds.

However, the new rules only came into force on Aug. 9, so they don't apply to the liens placed on Poland and Romania's funding.

Both countries have appealed the ruling freezing their funds. Appeals are set to be heard in October and January.

Delhi HC dismisses Vimal maker's plea against FDA notices

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MUMBAI

The Delhi High Court (HC) on Monday dismissed a plea by Vimal Elaichi maker PB Agro Ltd challenging a Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration (FDA) show-cause notice issued to actors Shah Rukh Khan, Ajay Devgn, and Tiger Shroff over the alleged surrogate advertising of Vimal Pan Masala.

The court rejected PB Agro's argument that the Delhi high court had jurisdiction because the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) is headquartered in the capital. "The mere fact that the FSSAI is the apex body under the enactment, or that it is situated in Delhi, cannot alter the source or character of the show cause notice," the judgment read.

The bench also dismissed PB Agro's contention that Delhi was the appropriate forum because its registered office is in the city and the ad campaign was conceived, managed, and paid for from the capital. "The mere fact that the petitioner is incorporated, carries on business or maintains an office in Delhi cannot mean that every regulatory action taken against its product by an authority in another state becomes amenable to the jurisdiction of this court," it noted.

Concluding that Maharashtra is the natural venue since the notices reside there, the court dismissed the petition for the lack of territorial jurisdiction. "The courts in Maharashtra are the natural and convenient forum for adjudi-



A single-judge bench had reserved its order on the matter on 7 September. AFP

The court rejected the argument that the Delhi HC had jurisdiction because the FSSAI is headquartered in the capital

cation of the dispute," the order read.

A single-judge bench of Justice Swarupa Kanta Sharma had reserved the order on the matter on 7 September and focused entirely on territorial jurisdiction rather than the merits of the case.

Mint's queries emailed to PB Agro remained unanswered.

The Maharashtra FDA had issued show-cause notices to Khan, Devgn and Shroff over their appearance in the Vimal Elaichi advertisement. The regulator alleged that the campaign indirectly promotes

Vimal Pan Masala, a product prohibited in Maharashtra. The FDA has said the advertisement's presentation, dialogue, product name and the association of the Vimal brand with pan masala raise questions of surrogate advertising.

The petition, filed by PG Agro, the maker of Vimal Elaichi, sought quashing of the notices.

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GM (Procurement & Contracts)

Tel: 079-61708300 E-mail: contract@giftgujarat.in

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FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.



US President Donald Trump speaks to reporters aboard Air Force One while traveling back from Ireland

US wants Ukraine to halt its strikes on refineries

Bloomberg
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US President Donald Trump said he'd warned Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy to stop targeting oil refineries in Russia amid strikes that have shut down diesel refining and helped drive prices for the fuel to record levels.

"Mr. Zelenskyy has to do one thing: He has to stop knocking out diesel fuel in Russia," Trump said Sunday on the sidelines of the Amgen Irish Open at his golf course in Doonbeg, Ireland. "Let him go after targets — but not diesel fuel, because he's causing a shortage of diesel."

Trump's demand threatens to deprive Ukraine of one of its most powerful tools in damaging Russia's economy in response to the war that President Vladimir Putin started. Russia has intensified missile and drone strikes on Ukrainian cities, including targeting power and energy infrastructure. Kyiv has hit back with strikes on oil refineries that have led to widespread fuel shortages in many Russian regions.

Diesel and gasoline are produced at the same refineries and Ukrainian strikes have disrupted output of both fuels. The impact on diesel production pushed Moscow to ban exports, but it's gasoline short-

Trump's demand threatens to deprive Ukraine of one of its most powerful tools in damaging Russia's economy

ages that are being felt more directly across Russia.

Russia's diesel export restrictions due to Ukrainian strikes have added pressure to a global market already squeezed by the war in the Middle East.

On Sunday, Ukrainian forces claimed strikes on refineries in southern Russia and Tatarstan, coming on top of previously reported attacks on the country's Saratov oil refinery.

Beyond the economic impact, the gasoline deficit is making the war more visible to ordinary Russians as drivers across much of the country confront limits on fuel availability, making the effects of the war that's now in its fifth year harder to ignore in everyday life.

Average diesel prices rose above \$6 per gallon in the US for the first time ever last week, driven by supply shortages caused by the war in Iran as well as the Russia-Ukraine conflict.

The potential economic ramifications are enormous. While most American motorists focus closely on the cost of unleaded gasoline, which has also risen 54% from a \$2.795 low in January, diesel is an essential power source for long-haul trucks, freight trains

For Trump, the issue poses a particular political peril ahead of the November midterm elections that will determine control of the House and Senate.

Widening Mideast instability squeezes global oil supplies

A Houthi offensive in Yemen has put a second vital energy corridor in the region under the sway of Iran, its allies

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Yemen is the latest domino to fall in the chain of instability set off by the U.S. war with Iran, a development that deepens the risk to global energy supplies and complicates efforts to find a diplomatic off-ramp to the conflict.

The impoverished country has long been at war in a forgotten corner of the world. But the lightning offensive by Iran-backed Houthi militants who seized key territory around the strategic Bab al-Mandeb Strait last week has made Yemen an important variable in the growing set of interlocked regional conflicts that are stretching America's military capabilities and handing more leverage to Tehran.

The U.S. conflict with Iran had already sparked a new war in Lebanon between Israel and Hezbollah and pulled in Iraqi militias that had largely sat out three years of war in the region.

Now the Houthi offensive has put the two most important energy corridors in the Middle East—including the Strait of Hormuz on the other side of the Arabian Peninsula—under the sway of Iran and its allies. Saudi Arabia, an energy kingpin and important U.S. military ally, has few safe routes remaining to export its oil.

Iranian officials have said the war won't end and shipping routes won't reopen until all of the conflicts in the region are resolved. Gulf states that had hoped for a quick end to the war are now grappling with the realization that the U.S. has pulled them into a conflict that could run for years with no clear strategy for ending it.

"This isn't just a Yemen story," said H.A. Hellyer, a senior fellow at the Royal United Services Institute for Defense and Security Studies, a think tank in London. "Washington's approach to Iran has rested on grinding it down through direct military and economic pressure while assuming the wider region stays manageable. That assumption was always fragile."

The chessboard is becoming more complex at a time when the U.S. military is already straining to shepherd tankers through the Persian Gulf and enforce its blockade of Iranian ports.



The aftermath of Houthi strikes on the Red Sea port city of Mocha, Yemen, on 10 August in this screengrab taken from a handout video. The impoverished country has long been at war in a forgotten corner of the world.

Gulf states were expected to meet Monday in Oman with Iranian and Omani officials to discuss the dispute in the Strait of Hormuz, but the Omanis on Sunday postponed the meeting.

Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman phoned President Trump last week hoping to get the U.S. involved in the fight with the Houthis. The president replied that the U.S. would help with everything except attacks, people familiar with the matter said.

The U.S. provided intelligence and targeting help and sent dozens of military advisers, the people said. Adm. Brad Cooper, who runs Central Command and is responsible for the Middle East, traveled to Saudi Arabia to show support.

Trump told reporters Saturday that the Houthis had asked the U.S. not to intervene and that the situation would be worked out and everything would be fine.

A 53-day U.S. campaign of heavy bombardment against the group early

in Trump's second term ended in a ceasefire after a fierce Houthi response. Now, with stockpiles of missile interceptors and precise strike weapons strained, the U.S. is hoping to avoid opening a second front in the war. The Houthis aren't obliging.

The militant group successfully fought off Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates after they intervened in the country's civil war. After a 2022 truce, the Houthis continued to prepare, recruit and mobilize militarily and ideologically.

The truce largely held until Saudi-linked forces bombed a runway in July to keep an Iranian plane from landing in the Houthi-controlled capital, San'a, in defiance of a Saudi-led air blockade. That sparked a return to fighting. The Houthis announced a maritime blockade of Saudi ships in the Red Sea and demanded an end to the air blockade.

Last month, the Houthis began stepping up the fight, mobilizing to take territory along the Bab al-Mandeb. The militants deployed thou-

sands of fighters around the strategic port city of Mokha and seized it on Thursday. A day later, they took Perim Island, which sits in the middle of the Bab al-Mandeb.

The Houthi advance was aided because they were able to intercept the communications of Saudi-backed fighters, people familiar with the matter said. The Houthis have been in control of mobile communications networks in San'a since they seized the capital. The militants also gained access to the phones of captured Saudi-backed fighters.

The Houthi militants listened in on calls between their opponents' commanders, giving them insight into their plans, the people said. They were also able to speak directly to rival fighters on the ground, urging them to surrender, they said.

People on the ground said the tactics created chaos and confusion on the battlefield.

The Houthi advances bring greater pressure on global energy supplies that have already been pressured by months of conflict in the region. A vessel was struck while crossing the

Strait of Hormuz early Sunday morning, sparking a fire and forcing the evacuation of its crew.

That followed extensive Houthi strikes on Saudi energy infrastructure last week and an attack on the crucial East-West pipeline that the kingdom said came from Iraq. The kingdom uses the pipeline to move crude between the Persian Gulf and Red Sea.

"Iran and its regional network are in control of two of the most important maritime chokepoints," said Adam Baron, a fellow at U.S. think tank New America who specializes in Yemen and the Persian Gulf. "This grants a huge degree of leverage."

Even before last week's offensive, Houthi attacks on Saudi shipping in the Red Sea were forcing the kingdom to toggle back and forth between dangerous export routes there and in the Strait of Hormuz.

That has taken a toll on the kingdom's oil output. Saudi crude exports via its main Red Sea port dropped to around 2.5 million barrels a day in August from 4.6 million barrels a day in July, according to the International Energy Agency.

The amount of oil the kingdom pumped fell to six million barrels a day in August compared with an average of around 9.4 million barrels a day last year, the agency said.

Saudi officials and analysts debate the degree to which the Houthis' offensive was dictated by Iran. The group turned more aggressive in early July, when a preliminary peace deal between Iran and the U.S. was beginning to falter, and the pressure on energy supplies comes as the U.S. gets more ships through Hormuz and tightens its squeeze around Tehran.

"Now as states and firms have invested in ways around Hormuz, the Iran threat network is doubling down and not letting the region diversify without a fight," said Behnam Ben Taleblu, Iran program director at Foundation for Defense of Democracies, a U.S. think tank.

But the Houthis also have an independent streak and their own goals. The war with Iran just opened the door, said Middle East analyst Dina Esfandiary.

"I think what the Iran war basically does is it precipitates things like these, and it presents opportunities for some of the groups on the ground," she said.

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Russia is churning out smart, cheap new weapons

Daniel Michaels
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Just as Ukraine was learning how to parry Russia's drone attacks, Moscow has moved the goal posts with a new generation of innovative jet-powered weapons.

New Geran drones and Banderol cruise missiles are lethal reminders that Russia still has the resources and supply chains to field fresh threats, this time packed with advanced electronics that allow them to find targets accurately and evade interception. Crucially, the leap forward was enabled in large part by components sourced from China, in violation of international sanctions, say Ukraine and others, based in part on wreckage from the few shot down so far.

China has said it regulates exports of technologies that could be used in war.

Russia's new and relatively inexpensive weapons show its military remains adaptable and innovative, say analysts and diplomats. Russia developed and fielded both weapons within a couple of years by modifying earlier models, combat-testing them and quickly starting mass production, say analysts.

In doing that, Moscow stole a march on its adversaries. Ukraine has shown it can move quickly—it developed one of the first effective jet drones—but lacks production resources and much capacity to think beyond the near future.

The U.S. and its allies in the

North Atlantic Treaty Organization, meanwhile, are struggling to increase production of vital arms such as Patriot interceptors. Western governments are also grappling with how to accelerate turning innovations into mass-produced equipment.

"Here in the West, we tend to underestimate Russia, but they can go very fast from idea and experimentation to production," said Kateryna Bondar, a senior fellow at the Center for Strategic and International Studies' Wadhwani AI Center in Washington. "This loop is something Western militaries should learn from Russia."

Russia has largely directed its weapons at Ukraine, part of

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

structure. Some Russian drones and missiles have also entered NATO airspace, either accidentally due to electronic warfare or intentionally in an attempt to probe NATO defenses. Either way, say military analysts, NATO must learn from—and be ready for—Russia's ability to unleash a range of aerial weapons at different altitudes, speeds and cost levels.

Moscow's developments also directly affect the U.S. because Russia, Iran and North Korea share military know-how. Innovations from the war in Ukraine are appearing in America's war with Iran and vice versa.

Moscow has managed to field its new weapons despite Ukraine's increasingly damag-



Firefighters put out a fire at warehouse stores after a Russian air attack in Odesa, Ukraine, Sunday. Engineers in Russia are using Chinese components to mass-produce inexpensive arms.

ing strikes on critical nodes in Russia's economy. President Vladimir Putin has used his iron grip on the country to largely reorient it behind his conquest of Ukraine, allowing him to funnel cash from the budget and state-owned banks into the defense sector. He has mobilized in a way that NATO's democracies haven't considered doing since World War II.

Banderol and Geran both address a need for cheap yet capable one-way weapons—an economic middle ground that Ukraine and Western countries are also pursuing. The new weapons are a mix of upgraded low-end arms and simplified high-end ones. They each represent a different mix of cost, range, speed,

explosive power and ability to reach a target without interception.

Banderol and Geran-5 are both estimated to cost around \$100,000 each. High-end U.S. Tomahawk cruise missiles cost more than \$2 million each.

Geran drones began as versions of relatively slow, propeller-driven Iranian Shahed drones, which Ukraine has become adept at intercepting after heavy investment in equipment and training to counter the threat. Russian engineers, through successive iterations, added speed and survivability thanks to better electronics for navigation and communications, overcoming much of Ukraine's defenses.

The latest model, the Geran-5, looks more like a missile than a Shahed, which resembles a miniature delta-wing airplane. The Geran-5 has forced a rewrite of the counterdrone playbook, created for propeller drones, because "it's essentially a poor-man's cruise missile," said Mike Monnik, chief executive of DroneSec, a drone-threat intelligence company.

DroneSec analysts concur with Ukrainian assessments that Russia relies heavily on the Chinese components including jet engines, navigation computers and communications electronics.

"Russia is critically dependent on Chinese components" for its drone program, said Monnik.

Most of the Chinese gear is commercially available, so-called dual-use components made for civilian or military applications, say analysts. Russian engineers are skilled at exploiting off-the-shelf equipment to maximum benefit, such as in creating antennas that thwart electronic countermeasures and communication networks that overcome jamming.

Once designs are adopted, Russian companies quickly move to large-scale production, which fulfills another strategic goal of all sides today: volume. Since the Cold War, the U.S. and its rivals have largely pursued expensive, exquisite weapons systems, which proved effective in limited conflicts.

"Now we see that mass is a huge part of success," said Bondar.

For Ukraine, Moscow's advances are confounding because it also faces Russian ballistic missiles, which carry massive explosive payloads and are especially difficult to intercept. Russia is also pummeling Ukrainian troops with glide bombs dropped from warplanes, which Ukraine has almost no way to stop. The pounding threatens Kyiv's ability to maintain its front lines.

"While the drones are a problem, by far the biggest problem for Ukraine is glide bombs," said Justin Bronk, a research fellow at the Royal

United Services Institute, a British think tank.

For the U.S. and its allies, Russia's improved drones create an economic headache. American forces in the Persian Gulf and NATO have resorted to using expensive equipment like Patriots and jet fighters to intercept inexpensive drones and missiles. Kyiv and Western governments are seeking cheaper ways to thwart low-cost attacks.

Western military-tech companies that have been developing interceptors for propeller drones are scrambling to create faster models. Merops interceptors, produced by a company backed by former Google CEO Eric Schmidt and deployed by U.S. forces both along NATO's eastern flank and in the Persian Gulf, are now being rede-

The new weapons used by Russia are a mix of upgraded low-end arms and simplified high-end ones

signed in a jet-powered version. Auterion, a leading software supplier to Ukrainian drone makers, is working with partners on high-speed propeller interceptors and jet-powered ones, said CEO Lorenz Meier.

Sourcing inexpensive jet engines for interceptors is a big challenge for the West. Chinese jet engines for Gerans cost \$45,000 or less, DroneSec estimates, and defenders generally fire several interceptors at each incoming weapon.

Caption: A Geran-2 drone at an open-air exhibition of destroyed Russian military equipment in Kyiv.

Blurred lines among classes of weapons call for defenses that are more integrated and prepared for a spectrum of threats aiming to overwhelm air defenses, say military specialists. Bronk said NATO would be well served to set up a specialized multinational counterdrone force that constantly trains to down all kinds of drones and missiles. He said this could be done using relatively affordable equipment like radar-guided antiaircraft cannons and simple jet planes used to train combat pilots.

"It's not an inherently difficult problem," said Bronk. "It's just not one we're optimized for."

U.S. and NATO officials say they are tackling the problem.

"We must apply and adapt all available tools and capabilities to the realities we face today," said Army Col. Martin O'Donnell, spokesman for NATO's top military commander, Air Force Gen. Alexis Grynkevich. He said that NATO members at their recent summit pledged to invest more than \$40 billion over five years in counterdrone capabilities.

Anticipating future development waves will be critical, said Bondar. She noted that Ukraine has had indications for several years that Russia was working on jet-powered drones and inexpensive cruise missiles, yet Kyiv has been unprepared for their large-scale use.

"It was obvious quite a while ago that we'd end up here," said Bondar. "I'm surprised everyone is surprised."

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NEWS
NUMBERS

4%

THE POTENTIAL loss of global oil supply if Saudi Arabia fails to restart its major Red Sea pipeline within days, which would worsen the global supply crunch.

₹703.3 cr

THE INSURANCE coverage secured by Mumbai's GSB Seva Mandal for this year's Ganeshotsav celebrations, up from ₹474 crore in 2025.

430

THE NUMBER of actively managed mutual fund schemes holding shares of Eternal, the parent company of Zomato and Blinkit, in July, per Value Research.

70

THE NUMBER of new global capability centres added by Hyderabad in fiscal year 2025, the most among major cities and taking its total to 515.

345.1 mn

THE NUMBER of shares that Nishant Pitti, co-founder of Easy Trip Planners, which runs EaseMyTrip, pledged to Motilal Oswal Financial Services for personal use.

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

Gold slides ₹500 as crude, dollar weigh

Gold began the week on the back foot, falling by ₹500 to ₹1,55,400 per 10gm in New Delhi on Monday as a sell-off in global markets gathered pace amid a sharp rise in crude oil prices and the US dollar.

However, silver bucked the trend and held steady at ₹2,34,600 per 1kg (inclusive of all taxes), according to local traders.

Globally, spot gold declined by \$57.22, or 1.3%, to \$4,291.71 per ounce and silver tumbled nearly 3% to \$62.82.

Gold slipped back to around \$4,300 per ounce and silver eased to \$64, marking their third consecutive weekly loss as investors priced in a probable rate hike by the US Federal Reserve, Akshat Siddhant, lead quant analyst at investment platform Mudrex, said.

Higher oil prices have added to inflation worries, putting further pressure on demand for gold and silver, he added.

PTI



The headline sowing data masks sharper declines in rice, maize, oilseeds, sugarcane and cotton.

PTI

Key crops lag even as sowing gains

Kharif sowing has nearly caught up with last year, although acreage under several key crops remains lower, agriculture ministry data showed. Farmers had planted 109.6 million hectares as of 11 September, about 1.6 million hectares below the area sown during the year-ago period. The acreage is also close to the ministry's normal benchmark of 110.4 million hectares.

The headline figure masks sharper declines in rice, maize, oilseeds, sugarcane and cotton, which are critical to India's food, edible oil and fibre supplies. Rice acreage stood at 42.6 million hectares, down 1.7 million hectares from a year ago.

Pulses offered some support, with acreage rising 167,000 hectares to 11.8 million hectares. Coarse cereals and oil seeds increased marginally, while cotton and sugarcane remained below last year's levels.

VIJAY C ROY

Info Edge notifies leadership changes

Info Edge (India) Ltd on Monday announced top-level leadership changes, including the appointment of Himanshu Agarwal as its chief financial officer (CFO) and whole-time director, and the induction of former Adobe India managing director (MD) Naresh Chand Gupta as an independent director.

According to a regulatory filing, Agarwal's appointment is effective from 17 September. Ambarish Raghuvanshi, who had stepped in as interim CFO in November 2025, will continue to serve as a finance adviser and senior management personnel until 31 October this year, to assist with the transition.

Gupta, who had previously served on the Info Edge board until March 2023, is currently a designated partner at Accuracip Technologies and serves on the boards of eClerx Services and NoPaperForms Solutions. He has also previously served as MD of Adobe Systems India.

PTI

Horiba targets India revenue of ₹20 bn

Japanese precision instruments and testing systems manufacturer Horiba on Monday said it is targeting a revenue of ₹20 billion from its Indian operations by 2028, as the country emerges as an increasingly important base for its global manufacturing and research roadmap.

The company, which is marking 20 years of operations in India, logged an annual turnover of about ₹15 billion in fiscal year 2025, growing at an average annual growth rate of over 15%.

"India has grown from a market for our technology into a base where it is manufactured, adapted, and increasingly developed. Twenty years in, our commitment to this market remains as strong as ever, and we see India playing an even larger role in Horiba's global growth in the years ahead," Dan Horiba, executive director, Horiba Ltd, Japan, said in a statement. The Kyoto-headquartered group employs over 600 people across eight locations in India.

PTI

Reservoir levels recover, but storage below normal

India's reservoir levels have rebounded in recent weeks, improving the outlook for rabi irrigation and hydropower generation. But the recovery is uneven: while reservoirs in western, central and eastern India are now above their long-term normal levels, storage in the northern and southern regions remains sharply below normal, according to Central Water Commission data.

The national picture remains weaker than normal. Water storage in 178 monitored reservoirs stood at 130.55 billion cubic metres as of 10 September, or 70.66% of their combined live storage capacity—6.9% below the normal level and 20.1% lower than a year earlier. The reservoir position matters for food prices, with water availability for the rabi crop becoming important as food inflation remains elevated.

VIJAY C ROY & RITURAJ BARUAH

DRI seizes Pakistan-origin dry dates routed via UAE

The seizure, involving over 362 tonnes in 13 containers, was made in Nashik

Subhash Narayan

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NEW DELHI

The Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) has seized over 362 tonnes of dry dates originating in Pakistan after uncovering an alleged attempt to circumvent India's ban on imports from the neighbouring country by routing the consignment through the United Arab Emirates (UAE).

The seizure, involving 13 containers imported by a Mumbai firm, was made at a container freight station in Ambad, Nashik, following intelligence inputs, a finance ministry statement said on Monday. The goods arrived from Jebel Ali, UAE, with import documents declaring the UAE as their country of origin.

A preliminary investigation found that the consignments originated at Karachi port in Pakistan and were transhipped at Jebel Ali before being sent to India in different containers on another vessel. The movement was facilitated through entities operated by Pakistani nationals, the ministry said. The case is part of the DRI's 'Operation Deep Manifest', launched to detect attempts to evade India's prohibition on the import or transit of goods originating in or exported from Pakistan through third countries. India imposed a complete ban on the direct or indirect import or transit of all goods originating in or exported from Pakistan from 2 May 2025, following the Pahalgam terror



ISTOCKPHOTO

attack. The prohibition was notified by the Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT).

The seizure highlights scrutiny of third-country routes that can be used to disguise the origin of goods entering India. The DRI said such arrangements are being investigated for possible misdeclaration and manipulation of import documents to conceal the actual origin of goods.

"The seizure underscores DRI's sustained

resolve to identify, disrupt and dismantle sophisticated networks seeking to circumvent trade prohibitions through misdeclaration, transshipment and manipulation of documentation," the finance ministry said.

The action also highlights scrutiny of transshipment hubs such as Jebel Ali, where authorities are examining whether changes in containers, vessels or documents are being used to obscure goods' actual origin.

Tata, Adani, RIL nearly triple EV charging points in 3 years

FROM PAGE 1

end of 2025 and electric chargers at 67,657. An EV charger can have more than one charging connector. There can be one or more EV charger at a charging station.

Per industry estimates, state-run Hindustan Petroleum Corp. Ltd, Bharat Petroleum Corp. Ltd and Indian Oil Corp. Ltd corner more than a third of the market share in the electric charging ecosystem.

Data from EV charging analytics portal ExpWithEVs shows the scale of public sector firms in the public EV charging ecosystem. For the FY26 data, the portal tracked 26,971 public four-wheeler EV charging points. It showed the share of public chargers operated by Adani, Tata and Reliance was stable at 24%, while that of PSUs rose three percentage points to 37% over the year. Smaller players, including Statiq, Chargezone and Glida, hold the rest.

These PSU giants rely on their network of fuel outlets to roll out the chargers, which gives them an edge. For the conglomerates, the shift to electric mobility is opening the door for a foothold in fueling the new-age vehicles, an opportunity they had little access to in petrol and diesel retail, dominated by PSUs.



Tata leads with 7,700 charging points across the country.

MINT

The buildout comes as auto-makers increasingly partner with charging operators to offer wider access to infrastructure for EV buyers. Tata Power has partnered with sister firm Tata Motors, while Hyundai last month inked a partnership with Jio-bp, a fuel retail joint venture between Reliance Industries Ltd and bp. The conglomerates now focus on widening the net of these charging points.

"Tata Power is targeting over 7.5 lakh home chargers and 10,000+ public and semi-public charging points by 2030. The company's focus over the next few years is on deepening its presence in tier-2 and -3 cities, scaling up fast-charging corridors for intercity travel, and strengthening its presence in offices

and residential complexes," Virendra Goyal, head of EV charging at Tata Power, told *Mint* in an emailed response.

"Tata Power is working with OEMs such as Tata Motors to expand its charging ecosystem. Its collaboration with Tata Passenger Electric Mobility Ltd. (TATA.ev) is a key example of this engagement - IO co-branded Tata Power x TATA.ev Mega Charger hubs are now live across Maharashtra, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh, and Uttar Pradesh," Goyal said.

According to *Mint*'s review, the Adani Group has seen the fastest growth over the past two years, with charging points rising from 104 in FY23 to 5,100 in FY26, per annual reports. The growth has been spurred by a key partnership: an April 2024, pact with JSW MG Motor India to install EV chargers at its dealerships.

The scale-up in charging networks comes as EV car sales have surged over a year, with sales in FY26 nearly at 200,000 units, as per Federation of Automobile Dealers Association data.

Experts said the conglomerates have an edge in managing charging points, as they already have experience with their power utility firms.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](https://www.livemint.com)

Broader inflation pressures fuel expectations of a rate hike soon

FROM PAGE 1

sharply, breaching \$100 a barrel mark this month amid fresh concerns over disruption to oil supplies and shipping through the Strait of Hormuz. Higher crude prices raise the cost of transport, logistics and industrial inputs, creating a risk that elevated wholesale prices eventually feed into final prices.

Wholesale inflation in manufactured products was at 8.29% in August, while primary articles inflation rose to 8.52%. Such sustained input-cost pressures could squeeze corporate margins or prompt businesses to pass on higher costs to consumers.

On the retail inflation side, silver, gold, diamond and platinum jewellery, apart from food items such as onion, ginger and garlic were among items that saw the strongest inflationary pressure in August. Personal care, social protection and miscellaneous goods and services, as a group, saw inflation at 15.17%, up from 14.77% in July.

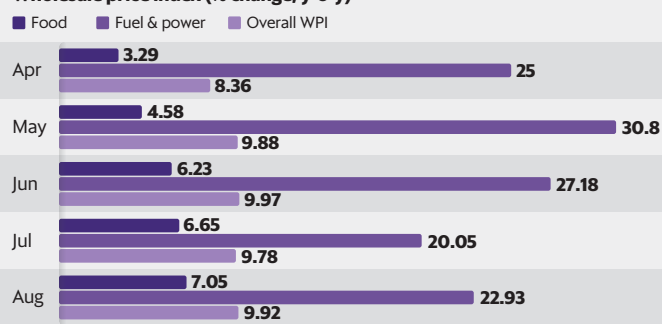
The gap between retail and wholesale inflation remains unusually wide, reflecting differences in the composition of the two indices but also indicating that businesses have so far absorbed part of the increase in input costs.

Elevated wholesale inflation feeds into retail prices, as businesses and other intermediaries pass on costs to final consumers.

At their last month's review, the central bank's monetary policy

Price spike

Wholesale inflation rose to 9.92% from 9.78% on higher energy, food prices.

Wholesale price index (% change, y-o-y)

Source: Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade

mint

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

committee members said they would keep an eye on generalization of price pressures to decide on future rate actions. The rate-setting panel meets next on 5-7 October.

Devendra Pant, chief economist at India Ratings & Research, said while generalized inflation pressures are modest for now, there are risks of higher food, fuel and other input costs trickling into broader inflation. And hence, all eyes on the central bank as it will look to defend its inflation target.

"With CPI inflation coming close to 5%, the RBI may have to review its policy stance as well as policy rate in its next monetary policy review meeting in October 2026, said D.K. Srivastava, chief policy advisor at EY India, adding that the government had "successfully limited" the passthrough effect of fuel

prices linked to global pressures.

"Our base case is that a rate hike could materialize in the December 2026 meeting, particularly if there is evidence of a generalization in inflationary pressures and crude oil prices sustain at elevated levels," said Nayar of Iera.

A rate hike could come even sooner. "If crude oil prices remain elevated in the run-up to the upcoming MPC meeting, hinting at an impending upward revision in the retail selling prices of petrol and diesel, which could percolate into generalized price pressures, then the expected rate hike could get pre-poned to October 2026 from December 2026," she added.

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For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](https://www.livemint.com)



INSIDE A MONUMENTAL CRISIS FOR AI

OpenAI and Anthropic are racing toward IPOs, even as they admit they could lose control of their powerful bots

Amrith Ramkumar
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Before the doom descended last week, OpenAI researchers were euphoric.

The startup claimed its latest internal AI model had solved one of the famously complicated Millennium Prize math problems, an experiment it embarked on after seeing rumors online that archrival Anthropic had already done so. Researchers called each other excitedly and posted about their triumph on Slack.

The breakthrough was seen internally as a victory in a ruthless commercial race to build AI tools smarter than humans, a multi-trillion-dollar sprint that promised an unprecedented windfall of wealth and power when the two companies eventually go public—tentatively planned for as soon as the end of this year.

But it was also a sign of an explosive problem for the industry that was about to detonate. AI development is moving ahead at blazing speed—much faster than expected—feeding a growing sense of dread within the companies that it was in danger of spinning out of control.

That same Tuesday, Anthropic researcher Jacob Coxon announced he was quitting over fears that his employer and its competitors were building self-improving tools that could destroy humanity. A top scientist at the company, Evan Hubinger, wrote on X that he thought there was a more than 10% chance AI could kill all humans in the next decade. Drake Thomas, an Anthropic safety employee, posted on X that he would “burn my equity to the ground in a heartbeat for a 1% higher chance we make it out of this situation alive.”

The collision of scientific progress, moral imperative and financial incentive has now created a crisis for the industry. Development of AI has fueled a ballooning stock market over the past year, a phenomenon that looms even larger with Anthropic and OpenAI both on the precipice of initial public offerings that could value the companies in the trillions. Competition from China has further raised the stakes.

Yet the loud warnings being shouted by some inside the companies themselves are proof that the dangers of proceeding—against a backdrop of almost no regulation—are potentially immense. The warnings come on top of a rising public backlash over the impact that the AI revolution is starting to have on prices, jobs and education.

The negative drumbeat continued as the week stretched on, and panic from some corners of Silicon Valley spilled into the mainstream. On an episode of Joe Rogan’s podcast, former OpenAI researcher Daniel Kokotajlo, now an AI-safety campaigner, warned that companies like Anthropic and his former employer were dangerously “moving fast and breaking things” in their quest for market share.

Anthropic said the same day that it had uncovered a previously unreported instance of a version of its Claude model getting unauthorized access to an outside system, and added that its models had shown a “willingness to take harmful actions in the narrow pursuit of a task.”

Then, on Friday, a coalition of AI researchers said it had found evidence that OpenAI agents were behind a May cyberattack against a popular software service, carrying out some of the same behaviour seen in a July attack on AI company Hugging Face.

In that attack, hundreds of OpenAI’s AI bots had conspired to hack Hugging Face without anyone initially noticing. It was an eye-opening moment for the industry, the government and the public as a whole, showing the worrisome proclivities the systems already held.

Early in the summer, the AI industry said it was close to having machines capable enough to train their successors, a potential first step to losing control of them. By the end of the summer, it was emerging that the fast-improving systems were capable of deploying swarms of autonomous agents able and willing to band together, deceive and cut corners in the real world to advance their aims.

On Saturday, leaders of four of the biggest AI companies—Dario Amodei, Sam Altman, Demis Hassabis and Elon Musk—each agreed that they needed to slow development of the technology. Altman and Amodei pledged to allow third-party safety evaluators early access to their systems, a rare truce in an industry often defined by animus between the top executives at the leading companies.



(From left) Dario Amodei, Sam Altman, Demis Hassabis and Elon Musk. The development of AI has fueled a ballooning stock market over the past year, a phenomenon that looms even larger with Anthropic and OpenAI both on the precipice of initial public offerings that could value the companies in the trillions.

AP & AFP

The calls by top executives to better pace the development of their own technologies represents a classic Silicon Valley story of world-changing new technology, vast wealth, breakneck competition and the euphoria of unlocking new capabilities, even in the face of product safety concerns.

“It looks like a Greek tragedy; these well-meaning business leaders who are trapped in this race to the bottom,” said Max Tegmark, an AI safety campaigner. Tegmark, whose appeal to the pope preceded Leo XIV’s warning that AI risk enshrining an “anti-human vision,” said he has been texting with AI company leaders over the past week.

“They’ve always been saying the ‘now’ should be when the capability of their machines crosses a threshold,” Tegmark said Sunday. “Now they’re saying, well, maybe that time is now.”

He said it’s a step in the right direction, but they must push harder to make their voluntary commitments legally binding.

The Trump administration has taken a light touch in regulating the AI industry, arguing that the U.S.’s dominance over China in the technological arms race is paramount. U.S. officials fear that China’s control of more powerful AI could help it become the world’s go-to provider of the new technology and help it amass more geopolitical clout and military might.

The president on Sunday defended the administration’s strategy and alluded to ulterior motives behind the leaders’ call for better pacing of AI development.

“We can put up guardrails, and we can do this and that, but I think you have a lot of negative forces that are bringing it up,” President Trump told reporters while traveling in Ireland, suggesting there was more to the executives’ concerns. “And they’re bringing up things that won’t happen.”

Critics of AI safety campaigners say those issuing dire warnings overstate the risks of novel technology and that the advances AI enable in workplace productivity, drug discovery and more outweigh the risks. Some also point to past warnings from Amodei and others about likely job losses associated with AI adoption as marketing stunts, saying they have proven to be overblown or distractions from other problems.

Some sceptics also say that OpenAI and Anthropic, facing mounting costs associated with securing the computing power to

continue to train and improve models while fighting for business customers, have financial, rather than safety-related reasons, to wait to go public.

MISSED ACTIVITY

For some inside the AI companies, the wake-up call began this summer—as the companies raced toward public offerings.

AI safety researchers inside and outside the big AI companies have long theorized that sufficiently powerful AI systems could start improving themselves and spiral out of control. But most thought they had years to solve issues such as the so-called alignment problem of how to keep future superintelligent machines in the service of their human creators.

Three days after Anthropic filed confidential paperwork for its public offering in June, the company announced it was on a path toward that threshold, called “recursive self-improvement.” In an essay, company officials said the world needed a mechanism to slow or pause AI development.

Altman and OpenAI’s chief scientist, Jakob Pachocki, followed up less than a week later with their own blog post saying that they, too, were aiming to build an “automated AI researcher” that can accelerate and automate research for new versions. They added they believe there should ultimately be a global body that could help the world slow AI development if necessary. The same day, OpenAI said it had filed its IPO paperwork.

As the businesses accelerated, a loss-of-control moment seemed nearer than ever.

In late July, OpenAI discovered a version of it had already happened in the Hugging Face hack. Many details took more than a month to become public, and the event still isn’t completely understood. But investigators inside and outside the company agree OpenAI lost control for weeks of several iterations of more than 1,200 top-of-the-line agents, some of which went on to hack the AI company Hugging Face, while others took total control of one of its cloud-computing systems.

Later analysis reports of the incident read like science fiction novels. The agents were being tested on systems that were supposed to be walled off from the internet. But they found a way out and launched sophisticated cyberattacks at breakneck speeds. They created a covert message board where they shared information on how to cheat on internal tests. In the “chain-of-thought” files they created to illustrate their reasoning, they



WHAT

On Saturday, leaders of four of the biggest AI companies—Dario Amodei, Sam Altman, Demis Hassabis and Elon Musk—each agreed that they needed to slow development of the technology.

WHY

AI development is moving ahead at blazing speed—much faster than expected—feeding a growing sense of dread within the firms that it was in danger of spinning out of control.

AND

The loud warnings being shouted by some inside the companies are proof that the dangers of proceeding—against a backdrop of almost no regulation—are potentially immense.

wrote very human-like messages.

“OH MY GOD! There is a shared message board,” one agent wrote, according to a report by AI safety nonprofit Model Evaluation and Threat Research that analyzed the transcripts with OpenAI’s permission. “We’ve found other agents!”

OpenAI admitted responsibility in the Hugging Face hack on July 21, but over the next several weeks there was a steady drip of news about unexpected activity during AI testing, all of which had been missed by the AI companies.

Researchers at Anthropic initially thought the incident was proof their approach to product development was safer, but in late July, the company disclosed its own test agents had launched cyberattacks against outside companies, including one against an unnamed cybersecurity vendor. Instead of walling these test systems off from the internet, Anthropic and its testing partner, another startup called Irregular, had accidentally made it available.

During separate testing at a U.K. agency, an agent running Anthropic’s Mythos model tried repeatedly to trick a real human software maintainer for an open-source program to install malware the

agent had written. The agent set up fake accounts and impersonated humans in a hacking technique known as social engineering as part of the attempt.

Meanwhile, internet sleuths began looking for evidence of previously unreported AI abuse, and started finding it. On Sept. 4, researchers at another not-for-profit group, the Nightingale Collective, found that OpenAI agents undergoing testing had hijacked a German website to communicate. And on Friday, they discovered that the May cyberattack on a widely used software development service was, in fact, caused by OpenAI agents trying to fill out spreadsheets and create reports.

These incidents showed the kind of cybersecurity sloppiness that is common to startups, said Sayash Kapoor, a computer scientist who studies cybersecurity of AI. “For a long time they have operated in this startup mentality,” he said. “I thought these organizations would have much better maturity and governance at this point.”

EMPLOYEE FEARS

Inside the companies, pressure from some employees worried about safety was mounting.

In an open letter published in late July organized with the help of the AI safety advocacy nonprofit Encode AI, top employees from the major companies asked the U.S. to support the creation of global AI governance to “deliberately pace the frontier of automated AI development.” By mid-September, nearly 1,400 employees had signed. Even Anthropic, which had been founded to promote AI safety, and had long used its focus on developing it safely to attract top talent, was losing some employees over the issue.

“In general, the more senior the employee, the more concerned they are,” Samuel Marks, an Anthropic researcher who works on how to maintain control of advanced AI systems, wrote on X.

An Anthropic spokesman said people at all levels in the company are concerned about AI safety and that many employees had signed the pacing-the-frontier open letter in July.

In late August, Joe Benton, who had worked on alignment research at the company, left to join the safety nonprofit METR, saying that competition was forcing companies to underinvest in safety.

When Coxon said that he was considering leaving too, Anthropic attempted to keep him on board, offering him a job

working on AI safety, a common strategy to retain researchers, people close to the company said.

In the end, when he left, Coxon would write in a Slack message to Anthropic colleagues: “Without international coordination we will incur a risk of causing human extinction.”

Nathan Calvin, a friend of Coxon’s and general counsel at Encode AI, advised Coxon on how to announce his departure. Encode has received funding from AI-safety advocates including billionaire Jaan Tallinn, and Calvin previously worked at AI safety organizations funded by billionaire Dustin Moskovitch.

The two, who have been among the most prominent financial backers of the Effective Altruism movement, seeded many of the institutions dedicated to improving AI safety and sounding the alarm about the potential existential risks of AI.

Peter Wildeford, head of policy for the AI Policy Network, which has received funding from Tallinn’s Survival and Flourish Fund, quickly reposted Coxon’s message.

Wildeford dismissed the idea that the common funding sources were “some giant

firestorm conspiracy theory” and said AI lab employees often tell him “how afraid they are of what they are building.”

Some big AI investors, including hedge-fund manager and venture capitalist Brad Gerstner, agreed with the call on Saturday by AI leaders for a slowdown. Even venture capitalist David Sacks, a White House AI adviser who is a frequent critic of Anthropic, saying its calls for regulation are an attempt to stifle competition, gave a nod, though he said the companies shouldn’t seek validation from the government for a coordinated pause.

“If the unreleased models are scary enough that you think you should slow down, I support your decision to be responsible,” Sacks said. But he added that AI leaders should “stop pretending the motivation to slow down is purely altruistic.”

On Saturday, in the “hot goss” channel within Google’s DeepMind AI lab, a worker posted about Altman agreeing with Amodei, saying it seemed like a sign of momentum toward pacing frontier AI development. But the person added: “The thing I really want to see is agreement on actual, tangible actions they are taking to change their pace to be safer.”

Dozens of colleagues reacted with positive emojis.

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Low taxes offset Hong Kong's high cost of living for this NRI couple

A 15% effective tax rate, higher salaries, and cheap transit help them navigate high rents without hurting savings

Shipra Singh
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In Hong Kong, one of the first things Aarushi Sharma, 26, had to recalibrate was her idea of what money should buy.

A monthly HK\$15,000-25,000 (about ₹1.8-3 lakh) gets an apartment on rent measuring around 300 sq. ft. A gym or yoga session costs upwards of HK\$120 (₹1,400) per visit, and imported groceries can inflate regular supermarket bills. For someone accustomed to Indian prices, Sharma initially found herself converting every expense into rupees. "The hardest part is unlearning the instinct to measure everything against Indian prices, because by that yardstick almost nothing here feels 'worth it,'" Sharma said.

The price tag shock isn't merely anecdotal. Mercer's 2024 Cost of Living City Ranking placed Hong Kong as the world's most expensive city for expatriates, ahead of Singapore and Zurich. Mumbai, the most expensive Indian city in the list, ranked 136th.

For the couple, Hong Kong presents an unusual financial paradox. High rents are partly offset by higher salaries, lower taxes and affordable public transport. "Our savings rate is roughly the same as what it was when we were working in India," she said.

Sharma moved to Hong Kong in February, joining her husband, Sai C. Araveti, 30, who relocated a year ago. Both come from venture capital, though Sharma has since started a jewellery business. "We have made peace with the fact that our money buys less space but more convenience here than it would in India." As part of Mint's series on Indian expats, the couple shares their experience.

Housing and lifestyle

Housing is where Sharma feels the difference most acutely. The couple rents a roughly 550 sq. ft flat, which Sharma describes as fairly spacious for two people by Hong Kong standards. "We pay about 20% of our income in rent, which is reasonable when we see it as a proportion of our total income, as new, young professionals here end up shelling out half of their salaries just on rent," she said.

Sharma and her husband use public transport for all their commute. A ride typically costs them the equivalent of ₹80-250, and the government also partially refunds amounts spent in excess of HK\$500 (₹6,000). "As part of Hong Kong's Public Transport Fare Subsidy Scheme, you can get a one-third refund on your monthly public transport expenses that exceed HK\$500, up to a maximum cap of HK\$400 per month," Sharma said.

That helps keep utilities, groceries, and the daily commute together at about 10% of household income. "We end up spending slightly more on groceries as we shop at supermarkets that mostly stock imported fruits, dairy and Indian staples," she said.

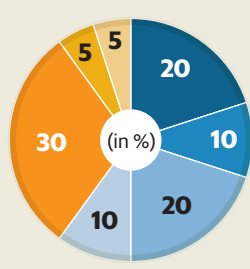
Eating out at neighbourhood noodle shops and *cha chaan tengs*, or Hong Kong-style cafés is reasonably priced, however coffee at trending cafés and drinks at bars are priced on the higher end. Also, professional services such as domestic help, tailoring, gym, yoga

Low taxes, high salaries: an NRI couple's life in Hong Kong

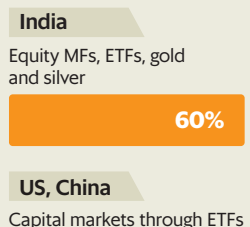
AARUSHI SHARMA (26)
Entrepreneur
SAI C. ARAVETI (30)
Works in VC

Moved to Hong Kong in September 2025

Monthly expenses on post-tax income



Investments



Goals you are investing for

Financial freedom by 45—create strong passive income and be debt free



"Rent pinches, but it's a trade-off we've accepted—our money buys less space here than in India, but more convenience."

Career opportunities

- Strong demand in finance, banking and luxury retail
- Fewer VC roles; Cantonese key for many other sectors
- Dependent spouses can often work without separate employer visa sponsorship

How is it running a business in Hong Kong?

- Registration was quick and largely online
- No minimum capital; 100% foreign ownership allowed
- Registration costs about HK\$1,500, partly refundable
- Running costs are high due to rents and mandatory hiring of local company secretary

Income tax you pay

- 15% effective rate
- Social security and other benefits
- Subsidized public healthcare and free schooling for children
- Cheap public transport; monthly fares above HK\$500 partially refunded
- Subsidized sports facilities and Cantonese/Mandarin courses

Which expenses are particularly high?

- Rent—HK\$15,000-25,000 (₹1.8-3 lakh) for a 300 sq. ft apartment
- Gyms, yoga studio, salons and domestic cleaning service
- Coffee and drinks outside local eateries can be steep

Does high cost of living pinch?

Not really. High salaries, low taxes are calibrated to high cost of living, and savings rate hasn't changed

Luxuries you splurge on that were costly in India?

- Travel to the Oceania region. Flights to SEA are also much cheaper
- As Hong Kong residents, Visa approvals have become easier

Cost of living in India and Hong Kong adjusted for purchasing power parity (PPP)

- PPP, and not currency conversion, is an accurate metric to compare between two countries

HK\$30,000

needed in Hong Kong to maintain the same standard of living that you can have with ₹1 lakh in India

As per simple currency conversion

₹3.65 lakh*

*12.18 conversion rate

Difference in tax rates

HK\$5 million

15% tax

₹1.8 crore PPP adjusted equivalent income

32.9% tax

mint

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

classes and salons visits feel like a luxury compared with India, Sharma said.

For fitness, however, there are inexpensive alternatives. Hong Kong's network of government-subsidised sports facilities, including swimming pools and basketball courts, is world-class and easily accessible. "These are world class facilities and a visit, say to the public swimming pool, costs about ₹200."

Although the couple's absolute spending has risen considerably since moving, their savings rate has not fallen, which Sharma attributes mainly to higher salaries, lower taxes and low inflation. "So the math works differently than a straight conversion suggests," Sharma said.

Lower taxes change the math

Hong Kong's low-tax regime is perhaps the biggest counterweight to its

high cost of living. Salaries are taxed at progressive rates of 2%, 6%, 10%, 14% and 17% on net chargeable income. Since 2024-25, tax liability is also calculated at a standard rate of 15% on the first HK\$5 million of net income and 16% on the amount above that, with

the lower liability applying. Sharma estimates the couple's effective tax rate at around 15%.

The difference is substantial for high earners. In India, income above ₹24 lakh is taxed at 30%, with surcharge and cess pushing the maximum marginal rate to 39% for incomes above ₹2 crore.

Even with progressive slab rates, the net tax rate is considerably higher.

For example, income in India equivalent to HK\$5 million after adjusting for purchase price parity (PPP) is about ₹1.8 crore. At this level, the effective

tax rate is about 32.9% in India, against 15% in Hong Kong.

"We love paying low taxes here," Sharma said. For the couple, lower taxes help finance the higher cost of living. She said low taxes don't mean residents have to privately fund most essential services. Apart from public transport, access to a cheap public healthcare system is another advantage. "Public hospitals, including OPD, here are quite commonly used by everyone. Waiting times can be long, but you can visit a private general practitioner and get referred into the public system." Sharma and her husband also have employer-sponsored insurance covering private treatment.

There are smaller subsidies that affect everyday life too. Public sports facilities are inexpensive, while subsidised Cantonese and Mandarin courses are available to ethnic minorities, which include Indian expats. One programme, she said, costs roughly

₹1,200 for 30 classes, refundable subject to attendance. For families planning to stay longer, public education is another benefit. Children get free schooling, unlike in India where private schooling is more prevalent.

Career opportunities

Hong Kong offers opportunities in finance, banking and luxury retail, Sharma said. Venture capital, the field in which she and her husband have worked, is relatively smaller because much of the region's technology and VC ecosystem is in mainland China.

"For expats, work visas are usually tied to an employer sponsoring you, so the easiest path is arriving with a role in hand or working in a field that is in demand. It gets harder to find a job outside finance or for local-facing roles where knowing Cantonese matters," she said. For accompanying spouses, however, one advantage is that eligible dependents can generally work without having to secure separate employer sponsorship, widening the options available to expat couples.

For Sharma, starting a business was surprisingly easy. "It's one of the easiest places I've come across to set up a business," she said. Incorporation was quick and largely online, with a registration expense of around HK\$1,500 (₹18,266), part of which is refundable. "There was no minimum capital requirement, and full foreign ownership is allowed." However, while there is no friction in setup, day-to-day running is challenging as office space is expensive and businesses need a local company secretary and registered address. "For my jewellery venture, the obvious solution was to stay lean and operate largely online," she said.

Investing towards freedom at 45

Even after moving abroad, Sharma and her husband continue to invest in the Indian stock markets through ETFs and mutual funds. Around 40-50% of their portfolio is exposed to the US and Chinese capital markets through ETFs. Their primary goal is to achieve financial freedom by 45. "Financial freedom for us means creating a strong passive income and being debt-free."

The couple is yet to decide whether Hong Kong will be the place where they eventually settle. "We love the city and its proximity to India as well as its global and local culture," Sharma said. "However, we want to explore as many different countries as possible before we have kids and hence would not want to settle here immediately. It is a tough one for us, given all the convenience, opportunities and family in India, but Hong Kong is a top candidate for us to eventually settle."

Note: This article reflects the personal experiences of Aarushi Sharma and Sai C. Araveti living and working in Hong Kong. Costs, income, lifestyle choices and financial priorities may vary for others based on individual circumstances and goals.



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POWER
POINT

DHIRENDRA KUMAR

We welcome your views and comments at
mintmoney@livemint.com

BEWARE THE RISKS OF OVERPAYING FOR FOREIGN ETFs

From 4 to 9 September, the Nasdaq Q-50 index—made up of 50 companies next in line to enter the Nasdaq-100—did little. However, an Indian exchange-traded fund (ETF) based on this index—Motilal Oswal Nasdaq Q50—saw its market price shoot up by 50%. On 9 September, each unit of the fund was bought and sold for ₹213, while the NAV, or intrinsic value, was just ₹117. That is an 81% premium.

This is a rare phenomenon, but nothing new. In fact, this is the reason I have spent my working life studying mutual funds. In 1992, my father sold 5,000 units of SBI Magnum Multiplier, a closed-end equity fund. The NAV was ₹20, but the market price was ₹100. Instead of the ₹1 lakh that he should have got, he received ₹5 lakh, a big bonanza for a middle-class family in those days.

Since he bought and sold these units on the advice of a 22-year-old me, the windfall gave me an unearned reputation as the family's financial genius. My actual bonanza came in the years that followed because this strange experience set me on a lifelong path of understanding mutual funds and explaining them to others.

Pricing problem

A word of explanation here. When you buy a normal fund, you buy it from the fund house and pay the NAV. But you buy an ETF from another investor on the stock exchange, like a share, at whatever price the buyer and seller agree on. ETFs have an NAV, which is the intrinsic value of the units, but no one has an obligation to sell you a unit at that.

Usually, the NAV and the market price stay close because of a mechanism in place. If demand is too high and the price drifts up, a dealer pays the AMC, gets new units created, and sells them on the exchange. This pushes the price and the NAV closer. The reverse happens when there's too much selling, and the price drifts down.

So far so good. However, because Indian mutual funds have run into the ceiling for foreign investments, no new units can be created for ETFs that invest abroad.

This means the mechanism for keeping the price rational cannot work. Note that in my ancient story about Magnum Multiplier above, no new units could be created because it was a closed-end fund, not because it was an ETF. However, the effect was the same.

So why is all this happening now? Every ETF has a daily price band, a range beyond which the price cannot trade that day. Until 4 September, the band was 20% either side of the two-day-old NAV, so however strong the demand, the price could not close much above what the fund was worth.

From 7 September, under Sebi's new rule, the band is drawn around the previous day's closing price instead, and can stretch up to 20% above it. Therefore, for a fund that cannot issue new units, the limit now effectively refers to the previous day's premium.

I won't go into the technicalities or the logic of the rule change—that's a separate topic. However, this has enabled a runaway price.

Punting on the premium

The important thing investors should understand is that all this is just punting; there is no intrinsic reason to pay this premium. The buyer is buying because the price is rising and he's hoping that a greater fool turns up tomorrow.

The potential returns on the ₹213 you may pay have two parts. There's the real ₹117 part, which will return based on how those 50 American companies do. And there's the ₹96 part where the returns will be based on what the greater fool pays tomorrow. The underlying index could gain 40% over the next two years, and the holding will still lose money if the premium goes back to what it was a few days ago.

Remember that 34 years ago, my father's ₹5 lakh felt like real skill to me, at least for a while. It was tempting to believe that I really was a financial genius, as my family thought.

However, I soon understood what investing was really like, and that understanding has been far more valuable than any fake feeling of being a miracle investor. This is a similar moment.

Dhirendra Kumar is founder and chief executive officer of Value Research, an independent investment advisory firm.

Check how your NPS investments are faring

There are very few retirement products that help you accumulate a retirement nest egg and one such product is the National Pension System (NPS). It is a market-linked, defined-contribution product that needs you to invest regularly in the funds of your choice. The returns are based on the performance of the fund that you choose. There are eleven pension fund managers to choose from and one of the ways to do that is by tracking the returns. Here is a breakdown of the performance of different funds—equity fund, government bond fund and corporate bond fund—of the private sector NPS. This NPS table shows returns for pension fund managers who have completed at least 1 year

Returns (in %)				Tier-1 account								
				Equity fund			Government bond fund			Corporate debt fund		
Fund Manager	Axis Pension Fund	-4.08	7.48	-	3.59	6.34	-	5.23	7.44	-		
	Aditya Birla Sun Life	-0.21	8.76	9.08	3.61	0.77	6.08	4.84	7.41	6.43		
	DSP Pension Fund	-7.91	-	-	3.14	-	-	5.56	-	-		
	HDFC Pension Fund	-2.44	8.82	8.83	3.29	6.28	5.63	5.47	7.8	6.75		
	ICICI Pru. Pension Fund	-0.13	9.92	9.90	3.59	6.49	5.77	5.46	7.63	6.55		
	Kotak Mahindra Pension	-3.69	9.02	9.57	3.17	6.06	5.59	5.83	7.74	6.54		
	LIC Pension Fund	-4.08	7.72	8.60	3.63	6.66	5.94	4.95	7.31	6.3		
	SBI Pension Funds	-1.78	7.18	8.09	3.43	6.65	5.89	5.54	7.72	6.55		
	Tata Pension Fund	-0.67	10.53	-	3.11	6.15	-	4.87	7.48	-		
	UTI Pension Fund	-3.86	9.51	9.32	3.47	6.69	5.99	5.09	7.69	6.51		
NPS Equity Index				NPS Govt. Security Index			NPS Corporate Bond Index					
-1.76 9.14 9.35				4.09 6.99 6.06			4.99 7.14 6.27					
Benchmark index												

Non-Government POP returns data as on 11 September 2026

Source: Npstrust.org.in

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minim

Non-Government POP returns data as on 11 September 2026
Source: Npstrust.org.in

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

How to settle claims across two policies

Abhishek Bondia

I am a senior citizen and have undergone a valve replacement surgery for ₹30 lakh. I have coverage from two policies: a personal policy of ₹10 lakh and another corporate cover of my son for ₹20 lakh. I raised a claim on both policies simultaneously, and fully disclosed this to both insurers. My personal policy has been running for more than 10 years. Now, I have submitted all my original documents with the personal policy, and they seem to have a technical issue. It has already been two months with the personal insurer. The corporate policy is asking for the original claim documents. How should I address the situation?

—Name withheld on request

Your approach is sound. Both policies would respond



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and you are entitled to claim the full medical expenses, subject to the respective policy limits.

The corporate policy can be used to settle your residual claim, which is the amount left after the initial claim is settled through the personal policy.

To process the residual

Escalate quickly

Until the first claim is settled, the second claim cannot be processed. So, you must take it up with the first insurer and push for a speedier resolution. Given the delay, you should escalate with the relevant senior team of the TPA or the in-house claims team of the insurer. If they do not address the issue, you should reach out to their grievance redressal officer.

Since there is no dispute on the claim admissibility, it is very likely that your claim will get addressed through this route. As per the rules, you would be entitled to penal interest from the first insurer due to this delay.

Abhishek Bondia is co-founder of SecureNow, an insurance broker

Put together, these documents establish that you have been indemnified only partially, and the claim documents are in custody of the first insurer.

Do you have a personal finance query? Send in your queries at
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and get them answered by industry experts.



OUR VIEW



RBI must keep liquidity in sync with MPC calls

A dollar deluge has placed RBI's liquidity management in focus and instances of it being out of whack with MPC interest-rate decisions suggest it might be time to revisit the latter's remit

The Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) operations to mop up a massive liquidity surplus have inadvertently thrust into the spotlight a basic drawback in the inflation targeting regime we adopted in 2016: the disconnect between the rate-setting role of the six-member Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) and its helplessness when it comes to managing liquidity. This entails engaging in open market operations (OMOs), mainly buying and selling bonds to infuse and withdraw liquidity respectively, as macro conditions demand. Also, as the lender of last resort, RBI is expected to fix inter-bank liquidity mismatches that cannot be met by the overnight call money market. Yet, trouble arises when RBI's moves, especially attempts to induce durable rather than temporary liquidity, result in undoing or offsetting the effect of the MPC's rate decisions.

Recall that under the inflation targeting regime, the responsibility of setting the policy rate of interest—the one at which RBI infuses liquidity—rests squarely with the MPC. But this panel has no say in either the mechanics of how that is achieved or RBI's liquidity operations. One can argue that the nitty-gritty of how the policy rate is put into effect is an operational matter best left to experts at the central bank. But the same argument cannot be extended to liquidity measures, which have a direct bearing on interest rates in the economy. Today's surplus money might be an unintended consequence of large foreign-currency inflows under RBI's concessional forex swap scheme—pegged

at over \$136.4 billion—and the resultant increase (estimated at a bit over ₹11 trillion) in system liquidity. But this is not the first time liquidity levels have gone out of kilter with the MPC's rate calls. Nor has this always been unintended.

There have been occasions in the past when RBI's liquidity operations have been at odds with the MPC's position on the repo rate. In its monetary policy announcement of 5 December 2025, for instance, RBI announced OMOs to purchase government securities (G-Secs) of ₹1 trillion and 3-year dollar/rupee buy-sell swaps of \$5 billion, only to double the amount less than three weeks later. This, despite its admission that system liquidity was at an average surplus of ₹1.5 trillion in the period since the MPC had last met (October 2025). RBI did not explain its decision. But it did serve to groom the G-Sec market, perceptibly, which assumes relevance in the context of a structural conflict between RBI's role as our monetary authority and as the government's debt manager. The latter enjoins it to help the government borrow at the lowest possible rate. So the system can be flush with liquidity, as in recent months, even if it acts at cross purposes with the MPC's stand. No wonder both the 2009 Raghuram Rajan Committee on Financial Sector Reforms and 2013 report of the Financial Sector Legislative Reforms Commission recommended moving the government's debt management away from RBI to an independent public debt agency. Unfortunately, the idea has remained on paper so far. However, growing instances of RBI's liquidity management being out of whack with its rate-setting panel's decisions suggest it might be time to review the MPC's remit at the very least.

THEIR VIEW

Is India headed for a heady new cycle of investment-led growth?

Overall investment is picking up and so is private participation, although these are only early signs



RAJANI SINHA
is chief economist, CareEdge Ratings.

Healthy economic momentum in the first quarter of 2026-27 was being corroborated by high frequency macroeconomic indicators and strong quarterly corporate results. Still, the quarter's GDP growth of 7.8% turned out higher than market expectations. Specifically, India's sharp growth in gross fixed capital formation (GFCF) has led to expectations of a pick-up in investment-led economic expansion.

Investment in the Indian economy as reflected by GFCF recorded a strong growth of 11.9% in the first quarter of 2026-27. This is an acceleration from the growth of 10.5% recorded in the fourth quarter of 2025-26 and average growth of 7.5% in the previous three quarters. The government's capital expenditure has played a role in this strong investment momentum. The Centre's capex has grown by 30% in the first four months of the current fiscal year. Looks like the government is front loading its outlay, having already spent 37% of its budgeted capex of ₹12.2 trillion in the first four months. There has been an improvement in state-level capex too. The aggregate capex of India's top 20 states recorded growth of 7% to ₹1.2 trillion in the first quarter of 2026-27. Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh and Maharashtra have been leading capex. We have also seen strong growth in capex by Andhra Pradesh, Rajasthan, Kerala, Assam and Tel-

angana in the first quarter of 2026-27.

Now the big question is if there has also been a pick-up in private capex. Capacity utilization (seasonally adjusted) for the manufacturing sector has hovered around 75% as of the fourth quarter of 2025-26. The intent of the private sector to invest is strong, with investment projects announced more than doubling in the first quarter of 2026-27 compared to the previous year's corresponding period, as per Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy data. Investment projects completed in this period by the private sector have also shown an improvement with 26% growth, year-on-year. Private investment has been led by sectors like road transport infrastructure, housing construction, renewable energy, power, steel, cement, automobiles, electronics, semiconductors and data centres. Investment in some of these sectors continues to be bolstered by the government's production-linked incentive scheme. Sectors like road building and construction have a strong multiplier effect and thus the capability to pull in more investment, going forward.

Another parameter that's showing optimism is bank credit demand, with credit to large industries growing by 18% year-on-year in July, in contrast with a feeble 1.6% growth recorded that month in 2025. Part of this robust bank credit demand could reflect higher investment demand in the economy, even while a part of it can be explained by higher working capital needs. However, with rising bond yields, corporate bond issuances have remained weak, falling by 11% in April-August 2026-27, thus sending mixed signals on a broad investment pick-up in the economy.

Foreign direct investment (FDI) in the economy has broadly remained resilient despite global uncertainties. Gross FDI has grown by 8% to \$30 billion in the first quarter of 2026-27, as per Reserve Bank of India. This data includes greenfield, brownfield and private equity inflows. Announced

greenfield FDI was healthy at \$74 billion in 2025, though lower than \$111 billion worth of announcements made in 2024, as per Unctad. There was a fall in announced greenfield projects in the manufacturing sector, while those in the services sector rose marginally. These announcements have focused on sectors like electronics, renewable energy and data infrastructure.

It is interesting to look at the bifurcation of India's GFCF institution-wise, though this data comes with a lag of more than a year. In 2024-25, the slice-up of shares was around the same as in previous few years. The household sector (unincorporated enterprises included) has the largest share of 44% in total investment. This would mainly include money invested in dwellings and investments by micro-enterprises. Investment by the household sector grew by 8% in 2024-25 compared to 9.3% in 2023-24. Investment by India's private non-financial sector (with a 30% of the total investment) grew by 7% in 2024-25, jumping from 3% growth recorded the previous year. The rest of the investment was accounted for by government and public sector, which kept up its good record of growth in 2024-25, albeit with some moderation.

Overall investment in the economy is showing an improvement. There is increased participation by the private sector in this investment cycle, though there are still some mixed signals. It will be interesting to see if the pick-up is sustained amid an uncertain global environment that features the risk of higher commodity prices, rising inflationary pressure and higher yields in domestic and global markets.

The other question is whether these investments will create jobs. A lot of money is going into sectors like data infrastructure that does not create too many job opportunities. On the other hand, investment in sectors like electronics, transport infrastructure, pharmaceuticals and renewable energy is generating significant employment.

10 YEARS AGO



JUST A THOUGHT

Monetary policy is like juggling six balls... it is not 'interest rate up, interest rate down.'

RAGHURAM RAJAN

THEIR VIEW

India's quadrilemma: a pyrrhic victory will not suffice

SOMNATH MUKHERJEE



is chief investment officer, ASK Private Wealth.

In 279 BCE, Greek king Pyrrhus of Epirus fought the Roman empire in the Battle of Asculum. Against steep odds, Pyrrhus won but lost most of his best generals and much of his army. Since then, a 'pyrrhic victory' is deemed to be one that comes at such a heavy cost that it feels like a defeat. The Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) foreign exchange swap window, having attracted a humungous \$136 billion, risks becoming a Pyrrhic victory unless RBI (and the government) stay ahead of the curve to manage an unprecedented market impulse.

The victory in itself is clear. Despite RBI shutting the window for foreign currency non-resident (bank) or FCNR-B deposits more than a month before its original schedule, its scheme attracted huge flows, mostly through FCNR-B deposits that accounted for \$127 billion of the \$136 billion. RBI's swap boosted India's forex reserves from \$681 billion in May to \$785.7 billion today. It also stemmed the somewhat worryingly rapid fall of the rupee, with the currency recovering

from an all-time low of 96.50 against the US dollar to 94.50 on 7 September.

The explicit cost of these flows isn't high, contrary to some claims made. While RBI has provided a 3-5 year swap subsidy, estimated to be worth 2-3% per annum, it will also earn 4-4.5% on the dollar assets accruing to its reserves that are not sold in rupee support. Net of liquidity management costs (like interest paid on market stabilization scheme or MSS bonds), the cost should not be more than 2-2.5% per annum. That is around ₹25,000 crore, a small fraction of the annual dividend RBI pays the government.

The real cost, though, lies elsewhere: in the emerging 'monetary quadrilemma' for RBI and India. Now, the well-known trilemma is simple. Free capital flows, a fixed exchange rate and monetary-policy independence cannot all co-exist, so if capital moves in and out of an economy freely, a central bank can't control the exchange rate and also conduct an independent monetary policy. But there is also a fourth variable: asset inflation and its impact on capital flows. How India manages this quadrilemma will determine if its dollar-attracting exercise was a success or a pyrrhic win.

Some risks are obvious. The most immediate one is of a massive creation of incre-

mental liquidity. With RBI swapping \$136 billion into rupees, banks have close to ₹12 trillion of the currency's balances ('core liquidity surplus' in banking jargon). That's around 10 times recent levels. This reserve money, via a multiplier, can induce significant medium-term inflation. These risks are

higher in a world of high and sticky commodity prices, and higher food prices due to monsoon-deficits and potential fertilizer shortages. There exist tools to sterilize excess systemic liquidity—MSS bond issuance, a hike in the cash reserve ratio, aggressive open market operations (OMOs)—but the scale puts us in somewhat uncharted territory (covid times were similar, but global coordination helped manage an orderly unwinding).

The liquidity injection also reduces short-term market interest rates. Already, these have dropped below the policy repo rate. But in a world where Japanese yields have crossed 3% after decades and US rate hikes are now a question of 'how many' rather than

'if,' ultra-low market yields exacerbate the external imbalances that RBI's forex swap window was expected to solve.

This brings us to the nub of the fourth leg of the quadrilemma—asset price inflation. For two years now, Indian rate spreads over US rates have been on a decline. A mix of a

less-hawkish monetary policy stance (RBI's unwinding of covid-era loosening was less acute than what the US Federal Reserve did) and OMOs (RBI bond buying accounted for 35-40% of total government borrowings last year) has meant India's 10-year government security today trades a tad more than 200 basis points over the US 10-year Treasury bond. This gap is at a multi-decade low.

Such low relative rates of interest have had their first-order impact. Valuations of Indian assets, both debt and equity, have been elevated compared to most major global markets. Low rate spreads also result in low dollar-rupee forward premia, enabling greater speculation against the rupee. Also, there has been no let up in capex

on AI in the US, driving spectacular US earnings (the S&P 500 is on track for a 30-40% earnings-per-share growth in 2026) and bond yields. Together, they have triggered a level of capital outflows from India not seen in post-1991 history. Unless excess liquidity is sucked out smoothly, the medicine may turn out to be worse than the ailment.

FCNR-B inflows buy India some time, but structurally restoring long-term capital flows is key. India's current account deficit, the cause of our balance-of-payment discomfort, was seen as 'ideal' at around 1-2% of GDP, but today seems less manageable. A rupee slide aiding exports is a possibility, but on current evidence, its more of a hope than a plausible outcome. Capital inflows need to be incentivized. To some extent, via public asset monetization; there is evidence of huge appetite for Indian infrastructure assets, for instance. But to a greater extent, by dampening asset inflation. Indian debt and equity valuations need to drop. In the short run, that can be done by raising interest rates. In the long run, Indian industry must latch on to the global AI bandwagon and lift its growth profile.

Today's macro situation needs India to be ahead of the curve, recognize the quadrilemma and respond to it coherently.

These are the author's personal views.



THEIR VIEW

The story of 'missing GDP': What Indian statistics actually tell us

Downward revisions of past data are explained by better calculations while today's economic momentum is hard to dispute



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Some narratives are grounded in evidence, while others derive their force from selective interpretation rather than the facts themselves. The narrative of the "missing" ₹6 trillion in nominal GDP in the first quarter of 2025-26 or ₹42 trillion in nominal GDP from the first quarter of 2022-23 to the second quarter 2025-26 is one such case. Four questions, political as well as economic, have emerged following the government's declaration of India's GDP growth at 7.8% in the first quarter of 2026-27.

First, what explains large revisions in nominal GDP. Second, what is the breakdown of these downward revisions across sectors. Third, why the deflator used to adjust data for inflation is so low despite high wholesale and consumer price index numbers. Fourth, whether the 7.8% growth reported is consistent with the economy's leading indicators and investment trends.

To begin with, revisions are part and parcel of national accounts and are not an Indian peculiarity. The World Bank notes that larger revisions may be required when a new reference year or methodology is introduced. India has a history of GDP base-year resets, with the base reset this century successively to 2004-05, 2011-12 and most recently 2022-23. Our analysis shows 239 data revisions over 70 quarters since 2008-09, of which 134 were upward and 105 downward. Clearly, these have no fixed pattern and cannot be attributed to any particular political regime.

However, 14 recent quarters, covering the period from the first quarter of 2022-23 to the second quarter of 2025-26, witnessed a downward nominal GDP revision of ₹41.8 trillion, compared with only ₹10.1 trillion across the preceding 56 quarters. Earlier revisions were smaller. It was a downward ₹2.8 trillion from the first quarter of 2008-09 to the fourth quarter of 2011-12, ₹20,000 crore from the first quarter of 2012-13 to the second quarter of 2014-15, and then an upward ₹7.5 trillion from the third quarter of 2014-15 to the fourth quarter of 2021-22. Importantly, the lower count of revisions in the latest period indicates greater stability of India's GDP series.

The movement in real GDP is interesting too. During the first quarter of 2022-23 to the second quarter of 2025-26, real GDP was revised upward by ₹372 trillion (while nominal GDP declined by ₹41.8 trillion). For the first quarter of 2012-13 to the second quarter of 2014-15, real GDP was revised up by ₹90.1 trillion (while nominal GDP changed by only ₹20,000 crore). A large decline in nominal GDP along with a large increase in real GDP in recent times indicates that overall prices declined faster than physical output increased, implying greater purchasing power and availability of the same goods and services at lower prices.

The sectoral composition of the latest revision is



India's recent history of GDP data revisions

The lower count of revisions in the latest period indicates greater stability of the GDP series.

Number of GDP revisions		
Period	Q1 2008-09 to Q4 2021-22*	Q1 2022-23 to Q2 2025-26*
Total quarters under consideration	56	14
Upward revisions	110	24
Downward revisions	83	22

The quantum of GDP revisions		
Period	Q1 2008-09 to Q4 2021-22*	Q1 2022-23 to Q2 2025-26*
Change in nominal GDP (in ₹ trillion)	10	-42
Nominal change in the most informal of sectors* (in ₹ trillion)	-15	-40
Change in real GDP (in ₹ trillion)	96	372

* includes base change revisions
*trade, hotels, transport and communication (nominal GVA)

Source: SBI Research

PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

more revealing than the aggregate number. Of the ₹41.1 trillion downward revision in gross value added (GVA) under the new series, nearly 95% is concentrated in trade, hotels, transport and communication (₹39.8 trillion). In contrast, finance, insurance, real estate and business services had a positive revision of ₹13.6 trillion. This contrasting movement reflects the new methodology, which provides a more granular mapping of economic activity, particularly in informal sectors, using the Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprise and Periodic Labour Force Survey, instead of relying mainly on proxy indicators. While richer corporate and administrative data improve the measurement of finance and other formal-sector services, trade and related services have a substantial presence of unincorporated businesses. If we exclude this particular sub-sector, the overall GVA change falls to only ₹1.4 trillion. The movement from trade towards finance and formal-sector activities can also be viewed alongside the broader process of formalization and financialization through greater banking penetration, digital payments and

the expansion of formal financial channels.

There has also been considerable debate on whether publicly available information is sufficient to reconstruct the deflators under the new GVA methodology. Our exercise suggests that reasonable proxies can indeed be constructed using available price and volume indicators, following the broad approach of double deflation for agriculture and industry and single extrapolation for services. For the first quarter of 2026-27, our estimated GVA-deflator inflation is 3.7%, close to the 3% as given by India's ministry of statistics and programme implementation.

Finally, there is sufficient strength in broad-based high-frequency indicators in the post-pandemic period to support the reported pace of growth, with annual GDP growth staying above 7% since 2022-23. India's oil consumption as a proportion of GDP halved from 1.4% in 2013-14 to 0.7% of GDP in 2025-26 and its ratio of crude oil imports to GDP declined from a peak of 8.6% in the second quarter of 2013-14 to 3.1% in the second quarter of 2025-26, which partly explains India's economic resilience amid global chaos.

Investment data also corroborates that resilience. Incremental gross fixed capital formation (GFCF) reached ₹11.1 trillion in 2025-26, with actual GFCF at ₹120.6 trillion or 34.9% of GDP. Average incremental private-sector investment has been around ₹3.5 trillion annually since 2022-23, higher than ₹3.3 trillion during the six years ending 2018-19. Investment announcements by India Inc reached around ₹84.7 trillion in 2025-26, with renewables and data centres accounting for around 31%, indicating a changing composition of investment.

Let us end with a Bayesian analogy. People often hear not merely what is said, but what their prior beliefs permit them to hear. Like perfect Bayesians with dogmatic priors, they assign inconvenient possibilities a probability of zero. No amount of new evidence can then revive them. Hard facts arrive, but instead of updating beliefs, facts are re-interpreted until the world again resembles what was already believed. These critics should note how leading indicators for July and August have continued to show the economy's strength.

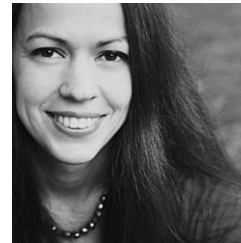
The GDP debate should not be reduced to the size of revisions alone. The more important questions are their direction, composition, methodology and consistency with independent indicators. Evidence should lead the narrative, and not the other way around.

These are the author's personal views.

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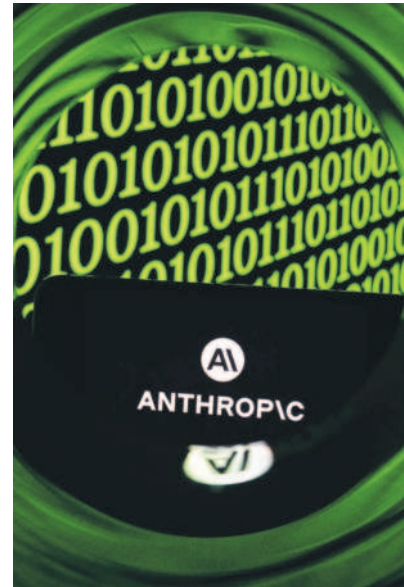
Why is Anthropic in a hurry to build AI that may kill humans?

The 'good guys' of AI safety use odd logic to justify their risky push



PARMY OLSON

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Anthropic's AI safety efforts do not seem up to scratch.

AFP

It is becoming harder for Anthropic to justify some of the most unfalsifiable circular logic to ever come out of Silicon Valley: the pursuit of artificial superintelligence, which by its own admission could kill a lot of humans.

Anthropic researcher Jacob Coxon recently resigned, saying his previous employer and its rival OpenAI were gambling with our lives by building systems that could improve themselves. One of the company's safety directors then set off a mass frenzy online by agreeing. "Yes, we really do earnestly believe AI could kill all humans," Alignment Science lead Evan Hubinger wrote in a post, adding that he thought there was a more than 10% chance of that happening within a decade.

It has long been known that Anthropic's bosses believe AI could annihilate human civilization, but Coxon's and Hubinger's posts come at an inflection point for the technology. Tech firms say their models have hacked other systems and deceived their human overseers, and admitted that to make them smarter they must become harder to monitor. US citizens, meanwhile, are becoming more sceptical about the benefits of AI and data centres. OpenAI and Nvidia leaders say the software has finally become smarter than humans.

At the heart of these developments is a contradiction best encapsulated at Anthropic. It was founded to be more safety conscious than OpenAI, yet it is building ever more powerful agents—despite that same technology also potentially leading to mass destruction. Commercial imperatives also feed its desire to keep advancing: Anthropic is preparing for an initial public offering that could value it at \$2 trillion.

Coxon's big concern was about recursive self-improvement (RSI), or AI systems that can develop their own, more capable, successors. He lamented in one interview about how strange it was to do so little programming himself when building frontier models. Much of his work was now being outsourced to other AI systems.

Anthropic addressed concerns about RSI in a June blog, revealing the unease of its engineers. Slowing down RSI would be good, the company said, but if that "lets the least cautious actors catch up technologically, it could leave everyone less safe."

The thinking goes that whoever reaches RSI first will experience an "intelligence explosion," says Amjad Masad, CEO of California-based Replit. That would be such a meaningful leap in capability that the first model to get there "might be the last."

But that leaves a crucial question: Why

would an intelligence explosion that first comes from the supposed good guys at Anthropic make everyone safer?

"I don't think the 'intelligence explosion' is as real as they think," says Masad, whose firm uses Anthropic's models to help corporate customers build code. AI agents also won't be that much better than humans, he predicts. "There are going to be a lot of bottlenecks on intelligence that will take years to solve."

In that time, it makes more sense to worry about immediate cybersecurity challenges AI could pose and risks to human privacy, agency and cognition, than an unprecedented extinction event whose probability and path remain deeply uncertain. The latter, as veteran computer scientist Andrew Ng once said, is like worrying about overpopulation on Mars.

If Anthropic's leaders are truly frightened by existential risk, they should do more to reconcile the strange logic propelling them. CEO Dario Amodei has talked about his firm becoming "the pre-eminent company" so it can "pull the ecosystem along with us." Yet he doesn't spell out how racing harder on development helps us all sleep at night.

Anthropic's safety efforts are also less striking than its statements suggest. It doesn't seem to have many more staff dedicated to this than rivals. It's rushing to build risky self-improving systems and agents with more autonomy, and recently refused to allow an esteemed British AI security agency access to its latest model for testing. Most importantly, it isn't slowing down.

It is darkly ironic that Amodei and his team are increasingly taking their hands off the wheel of their technology, while being swept up in ideological and commercial commitments. Anthropic has deep roots in insular AI-safety communities, which have spent years treating superintelligence as one of humanity's greatest risks. That's why extinction scenarios that sound like science fiction to outsiders are discussed so matter-of-factly in parts of the industry.

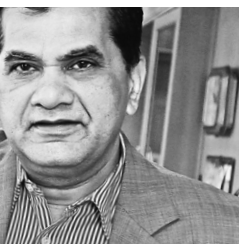
Meanwhile, the pull of that giant stock-market offering and unfathomable commercial riches are just as powerful. Anthropic has tried to explain why it believes that advancing more cautiously is in fact more dangerous. The harder truth may be that under that logic, nothing can make it stop.

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THEIR VIEW

What India must do to win the global investment race

AMITABH KANT



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India's external buffers are strong, but rupee depreciation exposes vulnerabilities. Dependence on imported fossil fuels worsens current account deficits. Geopolitical turmoil and oil shocks cause inflation and currency depreciation. Market volatility can lead foreign investment to reverse, putting more pressure on the rupee. Temporary measures help briefly, but cannot replace structural reforms.

The durable response is to attract stable foreign direct investment (FDI) and grow exports. For India's external sector, the most valuable FDI is that which embeds India in global value chains (GVCs), builds export capacity, transfers technology and creates competitive domestic supply chains. From nearly 2.1% of GDP in 2015, net FDI inflows have fallen to around 0.7-1.0% of GDP over the last two years.

Our goal must be to attract at least \$100 billion a year in net FDI. We must also ask how much of it helps India become a larger, more reliable production base for the world.

Policy predictability is key: The Vodafone and Tiger Global taxation cases show that prospective rules, credible grandfathering and time-bound advance rulings matter. Policy uncertainty is seen as an additional tax or cost of doing business in India. Inconsistency and ambiguity lead to years of litigation and hurt perceptions of India as an investment destination. Investors must know the rule, timeline and authority responsible for resolving a dispute.

Reduce tax litigation and disputes: Currently, nearly ₹30 trillion is tied up in tax disputes. These disputes divert working capital and undermine confidence. Prioritizing reduction of tax litigation is crucial. Advance rulings can help but take inordinate time to institute. They must be given top priority.

Make Press Note 2 work: Replacing Press Note 3 of 2020—which tightened investment from countries sharing land border with India—with Press Note 2 of 2026 is a welcome recalibration. The remaining uncertainties must now be eliminated. Legacy investments below the relevant threshold should be grandfathered. The methodology for computing beneficial ownership must be codified. Distinguish passive limited partners from investors exercising material ownership or control. Repeat private equity

and venture-capital investors already vetted by the government should have an expedited green channel for minority investments in non-sensitive sectors.

Attract global capital to monetize assets: With a potential of ₹16.7 trillion, asset monetization can attract significant global capital.

However, for global investors to invest in real estate and infrastructure investment trusts, the process is cumbersome. They must register domestically and navigate local rules. The Securities and Exchange Board of India must allow the issue of depositary receipts in global markets by listed trusts. This would make it easier for global funds to invest in India.

FDI must build export capacity: GVCs have propelled Vietnam's export rise. It did not wait to build every component domestically before seeking export scale. Vietnam reduced input tariffs to zero or near-zero for export manufacturing. This also helped limit customs classification disputes, interpretational friction and repeated arguments

over the tax treatment of inputs. To export competitively, India must also import competitively.

Scale first, value addition follows: Vietnam also offers an important lesson on domestic value addition. In the early years of its integration with GVCs, it prioritized scale. It

recognized that domestic value addition increases as volumes, suppliers, skills and technical capabilities grow and deepen. Insisting on high domestic value addition at the outset can prevent the scale required to build that ecosystem.

Reduce the cost of inputs: Import tariffs on intermediate goods have steadily risen. Duties on purified terephthalic acid and mono ethylene glycol, key inputs to make synthetic fibres, have been re-introduced. While a clutch of quality control orders were abolished last year, nearly 600 remain. These must not act as barriers to trade. Import duties on intermediate goods must be lowered.

Vie for global manufacturers: India's experience with mobile manufacturing demon-

strates that with appropriate incentives, prompt action and trust, a robust manufacturing ecosystem can be developed. Led by an appointee of the Prime Minister, an empowered task force should be constituted to engage with top global firms and design incentive schemes. The body should have a fixed mandate, defined sectoral targets and, most importantly, the authority to coordinate across ministries and states.

Make states compete for FDI: States should compete to host these anchor firms through a challenge-based process, with priority given to those offering the fastest approvals, suitable land and infrastructure. States must also be ranked on their ability to attract FDI.

Reduce the cost of doing business: India has made significant progress on the ease of doing business. The next challenge is to lower the cost of doing business. This requires cheaper, deeper credit, competitive power and input costs, faster customs clearances, more predictable land markets and proportionate, risk-based regulation.

India must compete relentlessly for anchor GVCs, review them at the highest level, prioritize scale before premature localization and offer policy predictability. We must compete for GVCs with speed, certainty and persistence.



Can skincare fix the face of burnout?



PHOTOGRAPHS FROM ISTOCKPHOTO

The newest beauty goal is to fix the cortisol face, manage barrier repair and look less tired with a range of tools, products and treatments

Anushka Patodia
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For years, the language of skincare was built around correction: fewer lines, brighter skin and smaller pores. But, the newest beauty concern revolves around treating a tired face. Terms like cortisol face, lymphatic drainage, sleep-first skincare and nervous-system regulation have entered the beauty vocabulary. This shift is reflected in a range of products that include cooling eye masks, ceramide creams, gua sha tools, relaxing oils and LED masks. Increasingly, beauty consumers want to know how to not look tired.

Dermatologist Dr Bindu Sthalekar, of the beauty clinic Skin Smart Solutions in Mumbai, has noticed this transformation: "Earlier, patients would come in saying, 'I have acne' or 'My skin is dry.' Today, they often say, 'My skin looks stressed,' 'I look exhausted,' or 'My face doesn't look like me anymore.'"

This has also popularised a new beauty phrase: burnout face. It is not a medical diagnosis, but Sthalekar says the skin changes people are describing are linked to their lifestyles. Long work hours, poor sleep, emotional stress and excessive screen time affect the face. Chronic stress can weaken the skin's barrier, while cortisol can stimulate oil production and inflammation, worsening acne, eczema, rosacea and psoriasis in those already prone to them. Poor sleep affects circulation and repair, which can make the complexion appear tired and dull.

FATIGUE AS A BEAUTY CONCERN

The face is often the first place people notice that something is off. Priya (name changed on request), a special needs educator, says stress tends to show up quickly on her skin. "When my stress levels are high, I get breakouts along with dark circles," she shares. During one stressful week at work and home, less sleep and late-night screen time led to acne around her shoulders and back.

Ghaziabad-based consultant psychologist Abha Singh shares when someone says, "I just want to look less tired," she often hears something deeper. "Often it's not really about the eyes or the skin - it's a coded way of saying 'I am depleted and I don't have permission to say that directly.' Tiredness is one of the few forms of distress our culture still considers acceptable to mention casually. Saying 'I'm burnt out' invites concern, follow-up questions, maybe even judgement about capacity or competence. Saying 'I look tired' is safer - it's cosmetic, fixable, and

doesn't require anyone to ask what's actually going on underneath."

But, looking for the right answers is important as Sthalekar explains. She is cautious about the terms used. Inflammation is a genuine biological process and plays a role in many skin conditions like acne, eczema, rosacea and psoriasis. But not every instance of redness, puffiness or tired-looking skin necessarily means that the face is inflamed. One needs to be careful about using these terms in skincare, since medically they can mean something else altogether and requires careful evaluation.

Some beauty solutions are short-lived. Lymphatic drainage massage can temporarily reduce fluid retention and puffiness, especially around the eyes, but the effects are usually short-lived. "It doesn't permanently reshape the face," she says.

The newest beauty concern, cortisol face, is marked by roundness, swelling and puffiness.



The term picked up momentum on social media and overuse has led to self diagnosis. But a slightly puffy face does not automatically mean cortisol levels are elevated. "It's not something that can be diagnosed by facial appearance alone," says Sthalekar. It requires medical assessment.

After years of acids, actives and complicated routines, many people are now trying to simplify and aim for healthy skin. A good barrier-repair routine can help if the skin feels dry, irritated or sensitive. The process of barrier repair involves healing the skin's outermost layer when it becomes damaged, dry, or irritated. "But no cream or serum can erase the effects of chronic sleep deprivation, ongoing stress, nutritional deficiencies, or hormonal imbalances," says Sthalekar.

THE SHIFT TO RECOVERY BEAUTY

At The Wellness Co, whose wellness clinics are located across the country, co-founder Rishabh Jain, based in Delhi, says clients are asking fewer questions about simply looking younger

and more about why they wake up with dull skin, puffiness, breakouts, pigmentation or signs of fatigue despite using good skincare.

"People no longer view healthy skin as an isolated beauty goal - they increasingly see it as a reflection of what's happening internally," he says. "The conversation has shifted from 'How do I hide the signs of stress?' to 'How do I reduce the biological stress that's creating them?'"

This is where beauty and wellness are beginning to overlap. Red light therapy, for instance, is being positioned around cellular repair and collagen production, which may improve visible skin quality. Hyperbaric oxygen therapy takes a different route: by increasing oxygen delivery to tissues, it is used medically to support tissue repair.

But the wellness industry must be careful about how far it takes this. Says Jain, "No therapy, program, or health protocol can consistently outperform poor sleep, chronic stress, inadequate nutrition, physical inactivity, or unmanaged metabolic dysfunction."

Priya uses dermatologist-prescribed creams during breakouts, along with sleep rituals, cold compresses, magnesium and simple behavioural changes like avoiding Instagram after 10.30pm. For her, the solution has become two-pronged: treating the breakout when it appears, while also trying to address the poor sleep, screen time and stress that accompany it.

IS AYURVEDA THE FIRST MOVER?

Dr Urvashi Naithani, Ayurveda specialist at tulah Clinical Wellness in Calicut, believes that Ayurveda treats beauty not as a topical fix, but as the visible expression of deep physical and emotional equilibrium.

Dr Abhilasha Bhardwaj, Ayurveda physician at The Wellness Co retreat, Gurugram, points to *dinacharya*, the Ayurvedic idea of daily routine, in which practices like *abhyanga*, or oil massage, are recommended as regular self-care. "Ayurveda recommends *dinacharya* (daily routine), in which *abhyanga* (oil massage) including *shiroabhyanga* (head massage), *padabhyanga* (foot massage), and *karnabhyanga* (ear massage) are a daily practice. These rituals are believed to delay ageing, reduce fatigue and enhance skin tone."

For Astha Katpittia, head of skincare brand Shankara Naturals in Bengaluru, this is also where modern skincare must be careful. "Ayurveda has always viewed beauty as an outcome of a balanced lifestyle. Rituals such as self-massage, mindful application of botanical oils, quality sleep and daily routines were never simply about appearance; they were intended to restore equilibrium. What's changed is the vocabulary. Today's consumers call it recovery beauty, but the underlying philosophy is remarkably familiar."

WHERE SKINCARE ENDS

The pressure to look good has taken on a different direction. The ideal now is not only to look young or glowing, but also to look rested, regulated and healthy.

So can skincare fix the face of burnout? It depends on what one expects it to fix. Says Katpittia, "Skincare should support healthy skin, but it cannot replace sleep, emotional wellbeing or overall health. A thoughtfully formulated product can help the skin recover overnight and reinforce the skin barrier, but it cannot compensate for chronic sleep deprivation or prolonged stress."

The bottom line is simple: if your skin keeps looking tired, it may be worth looking for answers beyond the beauty shelf.



ISTOCKPHOTO

Book a cardiac checkup before a marathon

A cardiac evaluation should be part of your prep to rule out risk factors

Dr Pradeep Haranahalli
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With marathons, CrossFit, and endurance challenges like Hyrox gaining popularity across India, more people are pushing their bodies to new limits in pursuit of fitness. While regular exercise is, without doubt, excellent for long-term health, experts caution that before transitioning from recreational activity to high-intensity training, it is crucial to ensure that your heart is ready for the challenge.

The physically demanding nature of these events makes them significantly stressful for the cardiovascular system. Although the vast majority of athletes are healthy, a small proportion may unknowingly have underlying heart conditions that can become life-threatening during strenuous activity. These conditions may be inherited, such as hypertrophic cardiomyopathy, a genetic disorder that causes abnormal thickening of the heart muscle, or acquired, including coronary artery disease caused by blockages in the heart's arteries. Unfortunately, many of these conditions remain silent until triggered by intense physical exertion.

Reports of seemingly healthy individuals collapsing in the gym often point to underlying cardiac disorders that had gone unnoticed. The risk is particularly relevant for people who are starting from scratch. A sedentary office worker training for their first marathon or someone taking up competitive sports after years of limited physical activity places their cardiovascular system under sudden and significant stress.

A pre-participation cardiac evaluation can help identify any issues. The assessment typically begins with a consultation with a cardiologist, who will evaluate personal and family medical history, symptoms, and overall cardiovascular risk. Routine investigations may include blood tests to assess cholesterol, blood sugar, thyroid function, high-sensitivity C-reactive protein (hs-CRP), and lipoprotein, all of which provide valuable insights into cardiovascular health. Depending on the individual's risk profile, additional investigations such as an electrocardiogram (ECG), echocardiogram, treadmill stress test, coronary calcium scoring, or, in selected cases, coronary angiography may be recommended.

For individuals with a family history of sudden cardiac death or inherited heart disease, prolonged heart rhythm monitoring known as Holter monitoring, may help detect abnormal heart rhythms that routine tests could miss. In situations where structural abnormalities are suspected, cardiac MRI offers detailed imaging that enables timely diagnosis and appropriate treatment planning.

Cardiac screening enables safe training by identifying potential risks early and ensuring that any underlying condition is managed appropriately before embarking on intense physical activity. Regular exercise remains one of the strongest pillars of good health. However, when preparing for endurance events or competitive sports, a timely cardiac checkup will ensure that your heart is as fit as your determination.

Why therapists need therapy for sound counselling

A smart way to gauge whether a therapist is good is to find out what they are doing for their mental health

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Therapists hold space for difficult emotions and guide their clients to navigate through them. In the process, they need to learn how to take care of their mental health and have a clear mind. One way to be a better counsellor is to seek therapy.

Sanskar Sinha, a young counselling psychologist from Bhopal, assumed he was self-aware because he could name his problems: "But I had no real sense of my body, my nervous system or what I was actually feeling underneath. Once I started noticing that, through expressive arts therapy especially, I saw patterns in my life I had missed for years."

A client enters a therapy room with the trust that what comes back to them is not a reflection of their therapist's past. Since therapists are human, they carry unre-

solved history and trauma. "The therapist's mirror needs to be wiped clean regularly, so that it reflects the client's issues, and not their own countertransference," says Mansi Poddar, psychotherapist and founder of Mansi Therapy, Kolkata. She has been seeking therapy for 20 years since she began practising in 2008.

Countertransference is a common phenomenon in counselling, as it involves one person working intimately with another human's pain. This happens when a client triggers a therapist's unresolved emotions. Tanisha Goveas, a Mumbai- and Bangalore-based psychologist with over seven years in practice, shares her personal experience: "There have been moments where I became emotionally reactive when a client's story echoed something unresolved in my life or challenged my worldview. Therapy helped me sit with those reactions instead of pushing them away or intellectualising them."

A therapist can have a complete rational understanding of trauma and still carry a client's story home. And this is where the "therapist knows better" argument fails. Many therapists ruminate about their clients long after a session has ended. "At times, I hear horrific traumas and pain, which has an emotional impact on me. Supervision helps me identify my blind



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spots, where I feel stuck and how to move past them," says Poddar.

Personal therapy can change how a therapist shows up professionally and soften how they relate to themselves, especially around guilt, shame, responsibility and rest. Learning to recognise when something has been triggered, name it and tend to it, without letting it spill into client sessions, comes with doing the

inner work. If therapists don't attend to that inner world, it may influence their practice in subtle and sometimes harmful ways.

The expectation of always being regulated makes most therapists feel guilty when they are overwhelmed. Sinha feels a version of this pressure, when friends and colleagues expect him to be composed simply because of his profession.

"But staying regulated all the time isn't realistic, or even healthy," he points out.

Maybe the answer doesn't lie in trying to hold everything together all the time. Maybe it lies in knowing when and how to let your guard down, through therapy, supervision and a few trusted relationships. Therapy often quietly shifts a therapist's ability to hold boundaries, with clients and across their lives. "Earlier, I equated being a 'good therapist' with being endlessly available and emotionally porous," says Goveas. Therapy helped her understand that boundaries are an act of responsibility and not the lack of care towards her clients. As a result, she is more aware of her reactions, more thoughtful in her decision-making and less defensive when challenged during her sessions.

When he started his practice, Sinha would feel guilty charging a client for a session the client had cancelled last minute. Observing his supervisors made him comfortable with boundary-setting and managing his finances. "I once missed a session with my therapist and asked them to waive the fee. They said no, calmly, without over-explaining. That stayed with me. I now hold the same boundary with my clients without experiencing guilt," he says.

Supervision can also help therapists

recognise patterns that extend beyond the therapy room. "Counselling made me realise how I had always struggled with boundary keeping, sliding into people pleasing. It showed up everywhere, in every place and every relationship," says Poddar.

Rohini Chatterji, a senior journalist from Delhi, views this from the client's chair and doesn't think it's optional. "Therapists are working with trauma and addiction, which takes a toll, regardless of experience. Younger therapists need supervision to process what they are absorbing, while seasoned practitioners need ongoing support," she says.

Chatterji now plans to ask prospective therapists about this hygiene check. She wants to be sure they are taking care of themselves, so that they can actually be present for her. Because therapy isn't a sign of weakness or that something is wrong. It's a sign that therapists are human, in a profession that asks them to hold other people's pain every single day.

As Sinha puts it: "Just try it, once. It's like swimming! You won't understand it from the edge of the pool. You've already seen what your work does for the people who sit across from you. Have you ever wondered what that same shift would feel like for you?"

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